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Title

The Achievable Confidence Illusion: A Multimodal Critical Analysis of Postfeminist Discipline in Chinese Female Confidence Vlogs on Red Notes

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Abstract

The proliferation of female-oriented confidence vlogs centred on themes of "confidence" and "self-love" on the Red Notes platform has grown markedly. Yet whether these videos genuinely empower women or instead constitute a novel form of disciplinary mechanism remains an open question. Adopting a postfeminist critical perspective, this study conducts a systematic multimodal analysis of fifteen vlogs produced by five top-tier female influencers. The analysis reveals that confidence vlogs operate through the coordinated interplay of four dimensions-language, visuals, editing, and narrative-to fabricate what this study terms the "achievable confidence illusion." This illusion operates through four coordinated mechanisms: (1) linguistic responsibilisation – reframing structural inequalities as personal "mindset problems"; (2) visual toxic positivity – aestheticising struggle to obscure genuine suffering; (3) editorial deletion – systematically removing moments of insecurity to construct an unattainable "perfect confidence template"; and (4) narrative compression – offering linear transformation stories whose actual conditions of possibility are never named. Ostensibly empowering, confidence discourse in fact functions as a novel postfeminist disciplinary mechanism. This study introduces confidence culture theory into the Chinese digital context for the first time and expands its analytical repertoire through multimodal critical analysis.

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Introduction

Red Notes, China's leading lifestyle platform, has grown into a vast community with 339 million monthly active users. The platform's user base is characterised by a pronounced "young, urban, female" profile: female users account for 71.98 per cent of the total, and users aged 18 - 34 constitute nearly 80 per cent. Within this ecosystem, female‐oriented vlogs centred on themes such as "confidence", "self‐love" and "self‐improvement" have increased substantially, with those produced by top‐tier female influencers amassing considerable likes and saves, thereby coalescing into a distinctive digital cultural phenomenon. These videos typically adopt a first‐person perspective in which influencers share their personal growth experiences, life reflections, and journeys towards self‐acceptance, ostensibly offering female viewers an "achievable" template for confidence. Yet a paradox emerges: the more viewers consume such "confidence" content, the more acutely they become aware of their own perceived lack of confidence.

Orgad and Gill (2022), in Confidence Culture, argue incisively that contemporary confidence discourse individualises women's struggles, demands continuous self‐transformation work, and systematically occludes the structural inequalities that produce a lack of confidence. Drawing on Foucault's concept of "technologies of the self", they reveal how confidence discourse operates as a novel disciplinary mechanism that requires women to engage in constant self‐surveillance and vigilance. Banet‐Weiser (2018), in Empowered, further contends that contemporary popular feminism is deeply complicit with market logic, transforming "empowerment" into a consumable commodity and thereby co‐opting feminist discourse into the service of capital. McRobbie (2009), in her foundational work, characterises postfeminism as a "structure of feeling", arguing that contemporary gender culture reconstitutes gender power relations through ostensibly empowering discourses. These critical perspectives provide essential theoretical resources for understanding Red Notes confidence vlogs, enabling us to scrutinise the ideological operations that may lie beneath the surface of "empowerment" discourse.

Existing research has offered preliminary descriptions of the characteristics of confidence vlogs on Red Notes. Xu and Zheng (2025) find that Chinese influencers construct confidence as a "quality education" style self-improvement project, presenting it as an attainable and

necessary personal goal. Wei and Georgakopoulou (2025) reveal the operation of the "pretty girl" as a gendered chronotope – a term borrowed from literary theorist Bakhtin (1981) that refers to the intrinsic connection between time and space in a narrative, where specific temporal rhythms (e.g., "becoming", "waiting", "transforming") are inseparably tied to specific spatial settings (e.g., the dressing table, the gym, the camera frame). In their analysis, the "pretty girl" chronotope on Red Notes constructs "becoming beautiful" as a temporal project that unfolds across repeated, ritualised spatial practices, requiring continuous female investment. Chen and Peng (2024) explore how postfeminism constructs normative selfhood on Chinese social media platforms. Chen et al. (2026), through a computationally-assisted critical thematic analysis of the #RejectBodyAnxiety hashtag on Red Notes, identify the postfeminist rhetorical figures of "selective subversion" and "strategic compliance". However, these studies remain either largely descriptive or focused on specific topics (such as body anxiety or beauty tutorials), and have not adequately revealed the disciplinary mechanism of confidence vlogs as an integrated discourse type, nor have they systematically integrated multimodal analytical strategies.

Based on these research gaps, this study proposes the following core research question and sub - questions:

Core research question: How do confidence vlogs produced by female top - tier influencers on Red Notes transform postfeminist "empowerment" discourse into a novel disciplinary mechanism through multimodal strategies?

Sub - question:

- Linguistic strategy: How do influencers discursively transform women's structural struggles into "personal mindset problems"?
- Visual strategy: How do aesthetic strategies (filters, colour palettes, composition) produce "toxic positivity"?
- Editing strategy: How does editing systematically delete "insecure" moments to construct an unattainable "perfect confidence template"?
- Narrative strategy: How do linear self - transformation narratives construct a "mimicable but unreplicable" false hope?

To answer these questions, this study adopts a postfeminist critical perspective, takes Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory as its core analytical framework, and conducts a multimodal analysis of fifteen confidence vlogs produced by five top - tier influencers. The analysis systematically unpacks the operational logic and disciplinary mechanism of confidence discourse across four dimensions: language, visuals, editing, and narrative.

This thesis comprises five chapters. Chapter One establishes the theoretical framework through an integrated literature review. Chapter Two details the research methodology. Chapter Three presents the detailed findings of the multimodal analysis (complete coding is provided in Appendices A - F). Chapter Four develops theoretical discussions. Chapter Five concludes with findings, reflections, limitations, and future directions.

Chapter 1: Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

This chapter establishes a systematic theoretical foundation for the critical analysis of Red Notes confidence vlogs. It begins with postfeminist critical theory, revealing how "empowerment" discourse operates as a novel disciplinary mechanism; then introduces Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory; supplements this with Foucault's technologies of the self (Foucault, 1988) and Hochschild's emotional labour theory (Hochschild, 1983); and finally examines existing research in the Chinese digital context, thereby identifying research gaps. The chapter comprises six sections: Section 1.1 outlines the postfeminist theoretical framework; Section 1.2 elaborates on confidence culture as a specific postfeminist formation; Section 1.3 introduces Foucault's technologies of the self and its applicability to digital self-presentation; Section 1.4 discusses Hochschild's emotional labour theory in relation to vlogging as affective work; Section 1.5 reviews existing empirical studies on Red Notes and the Chinese digital context; Section 1.6 synthesises the above to articulate the research gaps this thesis addresses.

1.1 Postfeminism: Theoretical Origins and Critical Turn

Postfeminism does not refer to an "after-feminism" or the end of feminism, but rather constitutes a critical sensibility for understanding contemporary gender culture. In her seminal work, Gill (2007) argues that postfeminism should be understood as a "structure of feeling" that permeates media culture, reconstituting gender power relations through

ostensibly "empowering" representations of women.

To locate postfeminism historically, it is useful to distinguish it from the feminist waves that precede and accompany it. Second-wave feminism (broadly 1960s–1980s) focused on structural inequalities – such as legal discrimination, workplace barriers, and reproductive rights – and often framed women's oppression as collective. Third-wave feminism (emerging in the 1990s) reacted against what it saw as second-wave's universalising claims about "women's experience", emphasising intersectionality, individual choice, ambiguity, and the reclaiming of feminine aesthetics (e.g., makeup, high heels) as potentially empowering rather than inherently oppressive (Heywood & Drake, 1997).

Unlike third-wave feminism, which retains a critical political project and a vocabulary of structural oppression, postfeminism is not a coherent political movement but a cultural sensibility that works through, rather than against, neoliberal individualism. As Gill (2007, 2017) and other scholars (McRobbie, 2004; Rottenberg, 2014) have shown, postfeminist discourse constructs women as "self-monitoring active subjects" who are required to achieve self-empowerment through individual effort – not through collective action or structural change. In this sense, postfeminism can be understood as the neoliberal appropriation of feminist language: "choice", "empowerment", and "confidence" are detached from their feminist roots and redeployed as individualised obligations (Rottenberg, 2014; Gill & Orgad, 2018).

More contemporary movements — often termed fourth-wave feminism or digital feminism – have in some ways reacted against the postfeminist sensibility. Fourth-wave feminism, emerging alongside social media platforms in the early 2010s, is characterised by online activism, hashtag campaigns (e.g., #MeToo, #EverydaySexism), and a return to collective critique of structural forces such as patriarchy, rape culture, and workplace harassment (Munro, 2013; Chamberlain, 2017; Mendes, Ringrose, & Keller, 2019). Unlike postfeminism's individualised "confidence" solutions, fourth-wave activism insists on naming systemic oppression and mobilising collective action. However, as scholars have noted, these movements also coexist and sometimes overlap with postfeminist discourse on the same platforms (Banet-Weiser, 2018; Gill & Orgad, 2018; Banet-Weiser, Gill, & Rottenberg, 2020). This study attends to precisely such tensions: on Red Notes, confidence vlogs often

speak the language of "empowerment" and "choice" (postfeminist sensibility) while occasionally invoking hashtags and tropes associated with digital feminism – creating a complex and contradictory discursive field.

McRobbie (2004, 2009), in her analyses of postfeminist media culture, introduces the concept of the "feminist trick", arguing that postfeminist discourse reincorporates women into traditional gender disciplinary frameworks by "taking back" feminist gains. She contends that contemporary media culture ostensibly celebrates women's ability to "have it all", but in fact individualises structural inequality through operations of "responsibilisation" – a term originating in governmentality studies (Rose, 1996; Lemke, 2001) – referring to the neoliberal governance logic whereby social problems (such as gender inequality) are redefined as individual responsibilities rather than collective or structural obligations. As Lemke (2001) notes, responsibilisation extends Foucault's (1991) analysis of neoliberal governmentality, shifting the locus of social regulation from state intervention to individual self-management. In this process, women are held personally accountable for overcoming obstacles that are systemically produced. Rottenberg (2014) proposes the concept of "neoliberal feminism", revealing how contemporary empowerment discourse is deeply entangled with market logic and professional success discourse, thereby producing a new female subjectivity that demands "work-life balance"

Postfeminism manifests across three core dimensions. First, women are required to become continuously self‑transforming subjects. Psychological qualities such as confidence, resilience, and positivity are presented as women's personal responsibilities rather than outcomes of social support. Gill (2007) notes that postfeminist media culture exhibits a shift from "objectification" to "subjectification": women are no longer merely passive objects of the gaze but are required to become active subjects who "choose" how to present themselves. Second, empowerment discourse is deeply complicit with consumerism. "Choice" and "freedom" function as central rhetorical tropes, yet these "choices" are typically framed within the boundaries of consumer behaviour. Purchasing specific products and adhering to particular aesthetic norms are presented as manifestations of "empowerment". Banet‑Weiser (2018) terms this phenomenon the "empowerment industry", revealing how the market translates feminist discourse into marketable brand assets. Third, the discourse of individual choice systematically displaces structural critique. Workplace discrimination, gender‑based

violence, and the unequal distribution of care work are redefined as personal "mindset problems" or "lack of confidence".

At the same time, the operation of postfeminism in non‑Western contexts exhibits distinctive local characteristics. Dosekun (2015), in her study of Brazilian women's blogs, demonstrates that postfeminist discourse undergoes complex localisation during global circulation, becoming intertwined with local class, race, and national identity discourses. In contemporary China, postfeminist discourse engages in a complex negotiation among neoliberal narratives, consumer culture, and Confucian traditional gender norms. Zhang and de Seta (2022) find that postfeminist sensibilities are also prominent in rural Chinese women's beauty videos on Kuaishou, where self‑fashioning and economic independence are presented as "remedies" to patriarchal marriage. Wang (2023) reveals the phenomenon of "consumerist pseudo‑feminism" on Chinese social media, where women are encouraged to "love themselves" through consumption, thereby co‑opting feminist discourse into the service of capital accumulation. Yang (2024) examines how entrepreneurial labour on Douyin is co‑opted by postfeminist discourse, revealing how "female entrepreneurship" discourse individualises the pressures of economic downturn into women's personal self‑improvement responsibilities.

This theoretical turn carries significant critical implications. Postfeminism ostensibly grants women unprecedented autonomy, but in fact imposes new disciplinary demands. Women are subjected not only to discipline in traditional domains such as family and appearance, but also to continuous pressure in new domains such as professional success, emotional management, and bodily display. As Orgad and Gill (2022) argue, ostensibly liberating slogans such as "be yourself" and "believe in yourself" in fact demand nearly constant self‑surveillance and inner work from women.

1.2 Confidence Culture: From the West to China

Confidence culture is the core concept developed by Orgad and Gill (2022) in their co‑authored book. The work systematically critiques confidence discourse targeting women in contemporary society, revealing a paradox: confidence is presented as a "panacea" for all women's problems-from workplace success to intimate relationships, from body image to

motherhood-while lack of confidence is framed as the fundamental obstacle preventing women from moving forward. However, this discourse in fact transforms structural inequalities into individual psychological problems.

Orgad and Gill's theory comprises three interconnected critical concepts: individual responsibilisation, self‐transformation work, and structural occlusion. These theories will be empirically validated through specific data in Chapter Three. The coding analyses presented in Appendices A—F demonstrate how the five influencers reproduce the logic of individual responsibilisation to varying degrees.

The insidiousness of confidence culture lies in its "empowerment" camouflage. As Orgad and Gill (2022) argue, confidence discourse leads women to "believe that the problem is not that our workplaces still fail to cultivate meaningful inclusion, not that our bodies are systematically disciplined by beauty standards, not that motherhood is structured by impossible expectations-the problem is a lack of confidence". This ideological operation redirects women's attention from institutional barriers towards self‐improvement, thereby rendering them complicit, unwittingly, in the reproduction of power structures that disadvantage them.

In the domain of body confidence, the operation of confidence discourse is particularly visible. Gill and Orgad's (2015) critical analysis of "confident body" discourse demonstrates that the so‐called body confidence movement does not genuinely challenge the hegemony of thin aesthetics but rather repackages it: "love your body" becomes a new disciplinary command requiring women to feel "confident" about their bodies on pain of personal failure. This "positive body image" discourse and traditional "negative body image" discourse, ostensibly opposed, in fact share the same underlying logic: women's bodily value remains the primary focus of concern. Kanai (2019), in her analysis of postfeminist selfie culture, similarly argues that the "confident selfie" functions as a disciplinary genre requiring young women to perform confidence as a visible, aestheticised, and perpetually renewable personal asset. Chen et al. (2026), in their analysis of the RejectBodyAnxiety hashtag on Red Notes, find that Chinese body positivity discourse exhibits a characteristic of "idealised positivity". Through "selective subversion" (retaining idealised bodily presentations) and "strategic compliance" (packaging bodily management as individual choice), it actually reinforces

aesthetic hegemony under the guise of resistance. Keller's (2019) analysis of "girlboss" feminism likewise argues that the imperative to "stay positive" functions as a disciplinary mechanism that delegitimises anger, frustration, and other politically productive negative affects.

The applicability of these theories to the Chinese context requires careful evaluation. Confidence discourse in China exhibits distinctive characteristics. Xu and Zheng (2025) find that Chinese influencers construct confidence as a "quality education" - style self - improvement project, treating confidence as an attainable skill that can be "practised". This "cultivational" confidence discourse differs from its Western neoliberal counterpart in significant ways: it emphasises "effort" and "learning" over "talent" and "choice", resonating deeply with Chinese educational culture's valorisation of diligence and malleability. At the same time, confidence discourse in China also carries stronger collectivist undertones-confidence concerns not merely the individual but also family expectations, social evaluation, and even national narratives.

1.3 Supplementary Critical Theories: Foucault and Emotional Labour

A critical analysis of confidence culture requires deeper theoretical resources. This section introduces two supplementary theories: Foucault's "technologies of the self" and "discipline", and Hochschild's emotional labour theory. In his later work, Foucault (1988, p. 18) develops the concept of "technologies of the self", referring to the practices by which individuals "effect by their own means or with the help of others a certain number of operations on their own bodies and souls, thoughts, conduct, and way of being, so as to transform themselves in order to attain a certain state of happiness, purity, wisdom, perfection, or immortality". This concept provides a crucial analytical tool for understanding confidence vlogs: confidence vlogs function essentially as "instruction manuals" for technologies of the self-influencers demonstrate to viewers how to "produce" confident female subjects through specific practices such as waking early, exercising, grooming, and thinking positively. Foucault's theory of discipline reveals the microphysics of power: modern power does not operate through top - down repression but through the production of specific subjectivities. Confidence discourse exemplifies this "productive power": it does not prohibit women from doing things but actively "produces" a confident, active, self - monitoring female subject.

In the digital media context, technologies of the self take new forms. Duffy (2017), in her study of female bloggers, develops the concept of the "ideal worker", revealing how social media content creators internalise self‑branding, emotional labour, and continuous visibility as naturalised professional ethics. For female influencers, such technologies of the self are gendered: they must not only perform competently in professional terms but also maintain an "upbeat" emotional demeanour, conform to aesthetic norms visually, and at all times be "worthy of attention". This is a digital‑era variant of Foucault's *panopticon* mechanism-the camera replaces the watchtower, likes replace the supervisor's gaze, and influencers internalise external surveillance as self‑discipline.

Complementing Foucault's disciplinary framework, Hochschild (1983), in The Managed Heart, develops the concept of "emotional labour", referring to the management of feeling to create a publicly observable facial and bodily display. In the context of confidence vlogs, influencers perform gendered emotional labour: they are required to project "positive energy", manage negative emotions, and perform a consistently upward trajectory of positivity. Duffy and Hund (2015), in their study of female fashion bloggers, further argue that emotional labour has become an "implicit requirement" of social media content creation: bloggers must not only produce content but also continuously manage viewers' affective experiences, maintaining at all times a persona that is "positive", "authentic", and "relatable". This theoretical insight reveals a core paradox: confidence vlogs encourage women to "be their authentic selves", but this "authenticity" must conform to specific emotional norms-perpetually positive, perpetually confident, perpetually aspirational. Any moment of "insecurity" risks being edited out. This is not empowerment but emotional discipline. The concept of "toxic positivity" further illuminates the potential harms of confidence discourse. Biber et al. (2022), in their systematic review, define toxic positivity as the overgeneralisation of positive thinking to the extent that it denies, minimises, or invalidates authentic human emotional experiences. Confidence vlogs exhibit this logic pervasively: struggles are merely prologues to "breakthroughs" and "awakenings", and must ultimately be transformed into positive narratives.

1.4 Female Confidence Discourse in the Chinese Digital Context and Research Gaps

In recent years, Chinese scholars have begun to examine female confidence discourse on

social media, but systematic critical research remains limited. Xu and Zheng (2025), in their study published in Celebrity Studies, analyse the construction of confidence culture by female top‐tier influencers on Red Notes. They find that Chinese influencers construct confidence as a "quality education — style self‐improvement project, presenting it as an attainable and necessary personal goal. However, their study relies primarily on textual analysis and remains largely descriptive, failing to fully reveal the critical dimensions of confidence discourse.For example, Xu and Zheng (2025) identify recurring themes such as "persistence" and "self-acceptance" in influencers' captions, but they do not examine how editing techniques, gaze direction, or paralinguistic cues in the accompanying videos potentially contradict or complicate these verbal messages. Nor do they analyse how the platform's commercial logic (e.g., sponsored content, product placement) shapes what counts as "authentic" confidence. Consequently, their study describes what confidence discourse says but leaves how it operates disciplinarily unexamined. Wei and Georgakopoulou (2025), through small stories and positioning analysis of Red Notes beauty tutorials, reveal the operation of the "pretty girl" as a gendered chronotope. They demonstrate how beauty tutorials construct "becoming beautiful" as a temporal project requiring continuous female investment, echoing the "self‐improvement" narratives found in confidence vlogs-both treat the female body as an object in need of perpetual transformation. Chen and Peng (2024) examine how postfeminism constructs normative selfhood on China's Douban platform, analysing the concept of "girlfriend gaze" and demonstrating that women are required to perform "independence" and "clarity" in romantic relationships, with disciplinary demands embedded within ostensibly empowering discourses. Zhang and de Seta (2022) find that postfeminist sensibilities are also prominent in rural Chinese women's beauty videos on Kuaishou, where self‐fashioning and economic independence are presented as "remedies" and "warnings" against patriarchal marriage. Wang (2023) reveals the phenomenon of "consumerist pseudo‐feminism" on Chinese social media, where women are encouraged to "love themselves" through consumption, thereby co‐opting feminist discourse into the service of capital accumulation. Yang (2024) examines how entrepreneurial labour on Douyin is co‐opted by postfeminist discourse.

Overall, existing research exhibits three main limitations. First, a lack of systematic critical dimension-research tends to describe what confidence vlogs are rather than revealing how the

discourse operates as a disciplinary mechanism. Second, insufficient multimodal analytical dimension – confidence vlogs produce meaning across linguistic, visual, editing, and narrative dimensions, yet existing research has not systematically integrated analysis of how these dimensions co-operate. For instance, when a vlogger says "I am confident" while averting their gaze from the camera or using a rapid jump cut to mask a hesitation, the verbal message and the visual/editorial cues may contradict each other. A purely text-based analysis would code the statement as "confidence claim", whereas a multimodal analysis would reveal a more complex practice of self-doubt being edited out or managed. Similarly, the use of background music (e.g., upbeat versus melancholic), lighting (bright studio versus dim bedroom), and on-screen text overlays (e.g., "day 1 of confidence challenge") all contribute to meaning-making, but existing studies have not systematically examined how these elements interact. Third, the disciplinary mechanism of confidence discourse has not been adequately theorised or empirically demonstrated. For example, confidence vlogs often present self-improvement as an endless, never-quite-achieved project: one video leads to another, with each posing new challenges (e.g., "I gained confidence, but then I faced this new fear..."). This structure mirrors what scholars (e.g., McRobbie, 2009; Rottenberg, 2014) have identified as responsibilisation – the shifting of structural inequalities onto individual effort. However, existing studies on Chinese confidence vlogs have not explicitly theorised how these videos' repetitive, serialised format produces a sense of permanent inadequacy that keeps viewers returning for more instruction. Nor have they empirically demonstrated how specific editing techniques (such as the "before and after" time-lapse) visually encode the idea that confidence is always a future-oriented project requiring continuous labour.

Taking Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory as its core framework and integrating Foucault's (1988) technologies of the self and Hochschild's (1983) emotional labour theory, this study conducts a critical multimodal analysis across four dimensions-language, visuals, editing, and narrative-to reveal the operational logic of Red Notes confidence vlogs as a postfeminist disciplinary mechanism.

1.5 Multimodal Analysis as Method

Multimodal analysis originates in the social semiotic tradition. Kress and van Leeuwen (2001), in Multimodal Discourse, systematically develop this approach, arguing that meaning is produced not through language alone but through the coordinated interaction of multiple semiotic modes-image, sound, colour, layout, editing, and so forth. Each mode performs

specific functions in meaning production, and analysis requires examining the intermodal relationships.

Multimodal analysis is suitable for this study for the following reasons. Confidence vlogs are highly visual, heavily edited content forms. Their meaning is produced not through the single dimension of spoken dialogue but through the co‑construction of four dimensions: language (what is said), visuals (how it looks), editing (how it is organised), and narrative (how it is told). Analysing language alone would miss the disciplinary mechanisms operating at the visual and editing levels-for example, how filters produce toxic positivity, or how editing deletes moments of insecurity. The operationalisation of this study's coding framework is detailed in Appendix G.

The analytical framework of this study is as follows:

(Table 1: Analytical Framework for Multimodal Analysis)

Dimension |	Analytical Object	Critical Question
Linguistic strategy	Dialogue, titles, captions	How are social problems transformed into individual mindset problems?
Visual strategy	Filters, colour, composition	How does aesthetics produce "fake authenticity" and the "achievable illusion"?
Editing strategy	Rhythm, transitions, deletions	Where do the insecure moments go?
Narrative strategy	Storyline, transformation narrative	How does self‑transformation narrative become a "mimicable template"?

This framework integrates postfeminist critical theory with multimodal analytical methods, aiming to reveal the multidimensional operational logic of confidence vlogs as a postfeminist disciplinary mechanism.

1.6 Summary of Theoretical Framework

In sum, this study constructs a progressive theoretical‐analytical framework. It begins with Gill's (2007) postfeminist critical theory as the point of departure, revealing how "empowerment" discourse constitutes the underlying logic of novel disciplinary mechanisms. Building on this, Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory provides the core analytical tools-the three concepts of individual responsibilisation, self‐transformation work, and structural occlusion. To deepen the analysis of disciplinary mechanisms, it supplements Foucault's (1988) concept of technologies of the self (revealing how confidence vlogs operate as instruction manuals for self‐technologies) and Hochschild's (1983) emotional labour theory (revealing how confidence vlogs demand gendered emotional performances). Finally, through multimodal analysis (Kress & van Leeuwen, 2001), it operationalises these theoretical tools across the four dimensions of language, visuals, editing, and narrative.

This study explicitly adopts a critical stance in which the object of analysis is not individual influencers but the discourse system of confidence. The study does not question influencers' goodwill-they may genuinely believe they are helping others-but rather reveals how the discursive system imposes discipline through the guise of "empowerment". This stance is consistent with Orgad and Gill (2022). Building on this framework, Chapter Two presents a systematic multimodal analysis of fifteen confidence vlogs to answer the core research question.

Chapter 2: Research Methodology

This chapter details the research design and execution, including research hypotheses, research subjects and sample selection, data collection, analytical framework, and research ethics and limitations.

2.1 Research Hypotheses

To answer the core research question posed in the Introduction, this study proposes four research hypotheses based on the theoretical framework established in Chapter One.

H1 (Linguistic strategy): In the dialogue corpus of confidence vlogs, influencers tend to use individual responsibilisation discourse such as "you can do it," "don't overthink," and "you

didn't work hard enough," transforming social struggles into personal mindset problems.

H2 (Visual strategy): Confidence vlogs commonly employ visual strategies such as high brightness, warm colour tones, and soft‑focus filters. Even content discussing "lows" is aesthetically packaged, filtering out genuine discomfort and producing an "everything will be fine" optimistic illusion.

H3 (Editing strategy): The editing rhythm of confidence vlogs is generally fast, with few "stutters," "pauses," or "mistakes"-imperfect moments are systematically absent, constructing an unattainable "perfect confidence template".

H4 (Narrative strategy): Confidence vlogs generally follow a linear "struggle → awakening → action → transformation" narrative structure, offering seemingly actionable "success formulas," but influencers' success typically depends on unreplicable personal conditions, thereby constructing a "mimicable but unreplicable" false hope.

2.2 Research Subjects and Sample Selection

The research subjects of this study are "confidence"‑themed vlogs produced by female top‑tier influencers on Red Notes. Female users account for 71.98 per cent of Red Notes' user base, making the platform representative of a female‑targeted content ecosystem. "Top‑tier influencers" (with over 500,000 followers) were selected because their content has greater reach and influence.

Sample selection followed these criteria (see Appendix H for detailed selection criteria): (1) influencer follower count exceeding 500,000; (2) video likes exceeding 10,00 per video; (3) video title or description containing keywords such as "confidence," "self‑love," or "self‑improvement"; (4) video publication date between January 2024 and January 2026; (5) video format classified as vlog (including direct address, life documentation, and opinion‑sharing formats), with a broad definition of duration-even very short content (such as thirteen‑second videos) was considered analytically valuable due to its high circulation and because it follows the same multimodal operational logic.

Following the principle of "stylistic diversity", five top‑tier influencers of different stylistic types were selected, with three videos each, totalling fifteen videos. The selection of the five influencers embodies diversity in style, age, and life stage. Complete coding analyses are presented in Appendices A‑F.

@Zhang Ti Jelina (over 1 million followers) is categorised as the value‑declaration type. Her core confidence narrative involves "abundant lifestyle scenes with encouraging declarations". Zhang Ti uses both Chinese and English in her videos, presenting confidence as an "elite" quality. This case is suitable for analysing how confidence discourse articulates with transnational lifestyle and class identity construction. Coding analysis is provided in Appendix A.

@Ling Yun Bao Dian (over 500,000 followers) is categorised as the body‑acceptance type. Her content focuses on appearance anxiety, emotional sensitivity, and related issues, with her audience primarily Gen Z women. This case is suitable for analysing how confidence discourse operates through psychological and medicalised language. Coding analysis is provided in Appendix B.

Xu Nao Nao (over 500,000 followers) is categorised as the trauma-recovery type with meta-critical elements. Her content focuses on CPTSD – that is, Complex Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder, a psychological condition resulting from prolonged or repeated trauma, often involving interpersonal victimisation and characterised by difficulties in emotional regulation, self-worth, and interpersonal relationships – as well as self-reconstruction and social media critique. Her videos are characterised by an unfiltered, imperfection-retaining "authentic aesthetic". Xu Nao Nao was selected using a "boundary case" strategy: if even a content producer who explicitly critiques confidence culture cannot fully escape the linguistic framework of individual responsibilisation, this provides powerful evidence of the pervasiveness and disciplinary power of confidence discourse. Coding analysis is provided in Appendix C.

@Shi San (over 1 million followers) is categorised as the lifestyle type. Her core confidence

narrative involves managing anxiety through "small actions" (hair washing, skincare, hydration), with a polished aesthetic and consumerist orientation. This case is suitable for analysing how confidence discourse is deeply complicit with consumer behaviour. Coding analysis is provided in Appendix D.

@Yang Tian Zhen (over 2 million followers) is categorised as the professional authority type. Her core confidence narrative is built upon verified career success. This case is suitable for analysing how "elite success narratives" are packaged as universal confidence templates. Coding analysis is provided in Appendix E.

The diversity of the five influencers ensures that the analysis can cover the operational logics of confidence discourse across different contexts, thereby identifying their common disciplinary mechanism. Cross‑blogger comparative analysis is presented in Appendix F.

2.3 Data Collection

Videos were retrieved and filtered through the XinHong data platform and subsequently downloaded directly from the Red Notes application. The retrieval period was December 2025 to January 2026. For each video, the following content was collected: (1) video file (MP4 format); (2) video title, caption, and hashtags; (3) interaction data (likes, saves, comments); (4) influencer basic information. All videos were stored by influencer category, with each video assigned a unique identifier (V001 - V015). An Excel sample log was established, and analytical notes were archived as Word documents.

2.4 Analytical Framework

This study employs critical multimodal analysis, conducted in three stages.

Stage One: Holistic viewing and preliminary coding. Each video was viewed three times. The first viewing recorded overall impressions: theme, emotional tone, and core message. The second viewing, conducted frame‑by‑frame, identified preliminary features across the four dimensions. The third viewing produced analytical notes.

Stage Two: Systematic multimodal coding. Based on the theoretical framework established in Chapter One, the following coding framework was used for systematic analysis. A complete summary of the coding framework is provided in Appendix G.

(Table 2: Multimodal Coding Framework)

Category	Specific Feature	Examples	Source
Language	Individual responsibilisation	"you can do it," "don't overthink," "you didn't work hard enough"	Orgad & Gill (2022)
Language	Psychologising discourse	"mindset problem," "self-doubt," "lack of security"	Orgad & Gill (2022)
Language	Self-transformation imperative	"do these five things," "stick to these three habits"	Orgad & Gill (2022)
Visual	Filter use	bright/soft-focus/vintage, intensity level	Toxic Positivity
Visual	Colour palette	warm/cool/high saturation/low saturation	Toxic Positivity
Visual	Composition	close-up/medium/long shot, blogger's position in frame	Toxic Positivity
Editing	Rhythm	fast/slow cutting, average shot duration	Foucault (1988)
Editing	Transitions	cut/fade/wipe, creative transitions	Foucault (1988)
Editing	Editing	visible jumps, unnatural	Foucault

Category	Specific Feature	Examples	Source
	traces	transitions	(1988)
Narrative	Narrative structure	linear structure of struggle-awakening-action-transformation	Hochschild (1983)
Narrative	Emotional framing	presentation of lows, climax design	Hochschild (1983)
Narrative	Transformation narrative	comparative presentation of "from X to Y"	Hochschild (1983)

Stage Three: Critical interpretation. Coding results were interpreted through a postfeminist critical lens, answering four questions: (1) How does each strategy individualise social problems? (2) How does it produce toxic positivity? (3) What structural problems does it occlude? (4) What disciplinary demands does it impose on women?

2.5 Research Ethics and Limitations

This study analyses only publicly available videos on Red Notes. It does not involve any interaction with human subjects (e.g., interviews, surveys, experiments), nor does it collect personal identifiable information beyond what is voluntarily made public by users. Following standard ethical guidelines for internet research (e.g., Association of Internet Researchers, 2019), analysis of publicly posted content without identifiable individual harm does not require formal ethical approval.

This study has several methodological limitations. First, the sample size (five influencers, fifteen videos) means the findings are not statistically generalisable, but the aim of qualitative research is theoretical generalisation rather than statistical inference. Second, the possibility of researcher bias cannot be dismissed. The coding and analytical process may have been

influenced by the researcher's theoretical presuppositions; systematic coding frameworks and detailed analytical notes were used to enhance reliability. Third, this study lacks an audience reception perspective. It did not collect data on viewers' actual responses to the videos and therefore cannot verify the real effects of confidence discourse on audiences. Fourth, there is a degree of temporal limitation. The 2024 — 2025 corpus may not fully capture trends after 2026.

Chapter 3: Multimodal Analysis of Confidence Vlogs

Based on the research design and coding framework described in Chapter Two, this chapter presents a systematic multimodal analysis of fifteen confidence vlogs. The analysis follows the three‑stage process: holistic viewing, systematic coding, and critical interpretation. The coding process employs twelve coding indicators across four dimensions (the coding framework is detailed in Appendix G). This chapter presents cross‑video synthesised findings, focusing on the disciplinary mechanism of confidence discourse rather than evaluation of individual influencers. Complete coding tables for each influencer are presented in Appendices A‑F, and cross‑blogger comparative analysis is presented in Appendix F.

3.1 Linguistic Strategy: "You Can Do It"-The Mechanism of Individual Responsibilisation

All five influencers' linguistic strategies exhibit a significant commonality in that they redefine structural struggles as personal mindset problems. The core mechanism is what Orgad and Gill (2022) term "individual responsibilisation"-shifting responsibility for social inequality from the institutional level to the individual level, leading women to believe that they themselves are the source of the problem and that only they can solve it. Linguistic strategy coding for each influencer is detailed in Appendices A.3, B.3, C.4, D.4, and E.4.

Zhang Ti exhibits the most direct form of individual responsibilisation. In V001, "strong women will never give up" sets "never giving up" as a defining characteristic of "strong women", with the implicit logic that if you give up, you are not strong enough. V002's "you are just now starting to understand who you are" attributes delayed self‑knowledge to personal responsibility. V003's "I either care about you or I don't, simple as that" reduces the complexity of interpersonal relationships to individual choice. See Appendix A.3.

Ling Yun Bao Dian's linguistic strategy focuses more heavily on psychologising discourse. V004's comment that "those with emotional instability should check whether they have gluten allergy" redefines emotional distress as a physical problem. V005's claim that "you must die for the queen to be born" invokes a Jungian psychological framework: in Jungian analytical psychology, archetypes are universal, recurring symbols or patterns in the collective unconscious. The “eternal girl” (or *puella aeterna*) is a feminine archetype associated with psychological immaturity, an inability to commit, and a refusal of adult responsibility. By framing the transition from “girl” to “queen” as a symbolic death, this discourse recodes what could be understood as structural or relational struggles (e.g., workplace discrimination, care burdens) as a matter of individual psychological development – specifically, the need to “kill off” an immature feminine self to achieve mature womanhood. This is a classic postfeminist move: a social problem is transformed into a psychological, inner journey requiring self-work rather than collective change. Both operations share the same logic: your problem is not structural but psychological or physiological. See Appendix B.3. A line-by-line analysis of V005 (01:52 — 02:28) demonstrates how this psychologising logic operates at the micro-level:

(Table 3: Line-by-Line Analysis of Ling Yun Bao Dian V005 (01:52–02:28))

Time	Utterance (transcript)	Rhetorical strategy	Theoretical link	Analytical note
01:52 – 01:58	"You feel stuck, right? Like you're an adult but you still feel like a little girl inside."	Diagnosis by empathy	Psychologisation	She names the feeling ("stuck", "like a little girl") as universal, inviting identification.

Time	Utterance (transcript)	Rhetorical strategy	Theoretical link	Analytical note
01:58 – 02:05	"That's not a failure. That's the 'eternal girl' – the part of you that hasn't been allowed to grow up yet."	Labelling as archetype	Jungian psychology	Reframes a relational/structural condition as an intra-psychic pattern. Responsibility shifts from external constraints to internal development.
02:05 – 02:12	"She's not bad. She's just... waiting. But you cannot let her drive the car forever."	Metaphor ("drive the car")	Individual responsibility	The metaphor implies agency: you are the one who can "let" or "not let" the eternal girl drive. No external conditions are named.
02:12 – 02:18	"At some point, you have to say: okay, little girl, I love you, but you have to sit in the back seat now."	Repertoire of inner dialogue	Technologies of the self (Foucault)	The solution is an internal psychological operation (a conversation between selves), not a change in material conditions.

Time	Utterance (transcript)	Rhetorical strategy	Theoretical link	Analytical note
02:18 – 02:28	"You've got to let her die. Because for the queen to be born... the girl has to die."	Metaphor of symbolic death	Postfeminist responsibilisation	The most extreme formulation: structural transition (girl → queen) requires not social change but symbolic self-annihilation. Failure is reframed as refusal to "die".

What is striking about this 36-second sequence is the absence of any reference to external structures — no mention of workplace discrimination, unequal pay, care burdens, or even relationship dynamics. The entire problem is located inside the woman's psyche. The solution is also located inside the woman's psyche (inner dialogue, symbolic death). This is psychologisation as a complete system: it explains the problem, provides a diagnosis, and prescribes a remedy, all without ever leaving the interior of the individual self.

Xu Nao Nao presents the most complex linguistic strategy. V008's statement that "healing is your own responsibility" explicitly draws on CPTSD therapeutic discourse, placing full responsibility on the individual while acknowledging the source of trauma. This is a characteristic operation of postfeminist discourse: structural violence is acknowledged ("the trauma you experienced is not your fault"), but the solution remains individualised ("healing is your own responsibility"). V009's admission that "my algorithm has a million ways to make me feel like a lazy, useless little piece of shit" is a rare acknowledgment of platform algorithms as a structural factor, yet the solution remains individual ("don't compare, find

your own pace"). See Appendix C.4.

Shi San most thoroughly eliminates structural factors. V010 redefines anxiety as "not washing hair," "not drinking water," and "not sleeping well"; V011 redefines the anxiety of turning thirty as a mindset problem; V012 redefines career difficulties as an energy management problem. As Orgad and Gill (2022) argue, confidence discourse "transfers responsibility for inequality and injustice from institutional and structural injustices onto women". See Appendix D.4.

Yang Tian Zhen's linguistic strategy is somewhat different. V013's statement that "being fat is just one of my characteristics, not a flaw" refuses external evaluation; V014 presents boundary-setting as a rational problem-solving process; V015 redirects the source of energy from external to internal. Nevertheless, she too locates the solution at the individual level – "be your own teammate," "know who you are" .

At first glance, these phrases appear less overtly problematic than the psychologising or pathologising discourse analysed above. They do not explicitly diagnose, blame, or demand radical symbolic death. However, their very reasonableness makes them, in some ways, more insidious. Unlike the jarring claim that "you must die for the queen to be born", which might provoke critical distance, "be your own teammate" sounds like benign, even caring, advice. Yet it operates through the same underlying logic: structural or relational problems are reframed as matters of individual attitude and self-relation. The question "why do you need a teammate at all?" – or "why is the default condition one of solitary struggle?" – is never asked. The discourse assumes that the individual is alone and must become sufficient unto herself. In this sense, Yang Tian Zhen's strategy exemplifies what scholars call "postfeminist common sense" (Gill, 2007): a mode of discipline that works not through explicit demand or crisis, but through the quiet, continuous injunction to turn inward, adjust one's mindset, and take responsibility for one's own well-being – without ever naming the external structures that make such self-sufficiency necessary in the first place. Her authority derives from her "already successful" position, a positioning that itself implies individualistic logic. See Appendix E.4.

In sum, although the five influencers adopt different linguistic forms (Zhang Ti's direct declarations, Ling Yun Bao Dian's psychologising, Xu Nao Nao's trauma discourse, Shi San's behavioural imperatives, Yang Tian Zhen's self‑definition), they share the same core logic: individualise the problem, personalise the solution, and systematically occlude structural factors. Cross‑blogger linguistic strategy comparison is presented in Appendix F.2.

3.2 Visual Strategy: "Everything Will Be Fine"-The Aesthetic Production of Toxic Positivity

The five influencers' visual strategies span a spectrum from "filter aesthetics" to "anti‑filter aesthetics". This difference itself reveals the plural forms of confidence discourse, but the commonality is that all visual presentations are selective and curated, each serving to construct a particular version of the confident subject. Visual strategy coding for each influencer is detailed in Appendices A.4, B.4, C.3, D.3, and E.3.

Zhang Ti's visual strategy is a typical representative of "filter aesthetics". V001, filmed on an Australian beach, features bright, warm imagery with the influencer impeccably made up. Even when discussing feelings of being "lost" or "insecure", the visuals remain warmly aestheticised. This produces a contradiction: the viewer hears her say "we need to cry, we need to stay in bed", but sees neither tears nor a bed. See Appendix A.4.

Ling Yun Bao Dian employs vintage filters, pink tones, and artistic B — roll to create an intimate, "healing" visual atmosphere. When she describes collapsing onto her bed and spiralling into rumination, her on‑screen self remains polished and in control. Genuine vulnerability-the unglamorous, chaotic, unfilterable kind-remains absent. See Appendix B.4.

Shi San's visual strategy is the most polished. V010 is filmed in a luxurious home setting, preparing the ground for La Mer product placement. The message conveyed is that this state of being can be achieved through consumption. See Appendix D.3.

Xu Nao Nao sits at the opposite end of the spectrum. She uses no filters, natural light, and appears without makeup, against ordinary domestic backgrounds. This "authentic aesthetic" constructs a different kind of confidence. Yet this "authenticity" remains a selective

presentation – a feature that is not unique to Xu Nao Nao but characterises virtually all social media content. The analytically productive question, therefore, is not simply that she selects (all vloggers do), but what this particular mode of selection accomplishes. Unlike the polished, aspirational aesthetic of other confidence vloggers, Xu Nao Nao's deliberate rejection of production values constructs authenticity as a performance of its own kind: the messy room, the unmade face, the unflattering angle are not "reality" but carefully chosen signs of reality. This reveals the postfeminist paradox of "authenticity" itself: authenticity is not a natural state but a performed one, and even the critique of performance cannot escape performance. See Appendix C.3.

Yang Tian Zhen occupies a middle position, using no obvious filters, filming in an office setting, with professional but unexaggerated makeup. This "professional aesthetic" conveys the message that confidence is not beauty but competence. See Appendix E.3.

Taken together, although the influencers adopt different visual strategies, each serves to construct a particular version of the confident subject. Zhang Ti's "desirable confidence", Ling Yun Bao Dian's "understood confidence", Shi San's "purchasable confidence", Xu Nao Nao's "authentic confidence", Yang Tian Zhen's "professional confidence"-each says, in its own way: this is who you should be. Each constructs an unattainable standard. Cross‐blogger visual strategy comparison is presented in Appendix F.3.

3.3 Editing Strategy: The Systematic Deletion of Insecure Moments

The analysis of editing strategies reveals the most special disciplinary mechanism of confidence vlogs: the construction of an unattainable "perfect confidence template" through the deletion of "imperfect" moments. Foucault's (1988) concept of "technologies of the self" is analytically powerful here: individuals shape idealised versions of themselves through specific practices, and confidence vlogs, as instruction manuals for such self‐technologies, demonstrate how editing deletes "imperfection" to produce "perfect confidence". Editing strategy coding for each influencer is detailed in Appendices A.5, B.5, C.5, D.5, and E.5.

Zhang Ti's V001 and V002 use a one-shot take, no transitions, and no visible cuts. This is not merely a technical choice but an ideological one. The influencer speaks fluently, without any

stutter, pause, or self-correction. This "no-editing" editing strategy produces an "authenticity" rhetoric: viewers feel that the influencer is speaking these words in a single take, as if they are her genuine, unrehearsed thoughts. But genuine "authenticity" includes imperfection. Real speech includes stutters, pauses, and hesitations. These moments of imperfection are not removed through post-production editing — there are no visible cuts where they could be excised. Rather, they are deleted through prior labour: repeated rehearsal, multiple takes (recording until a flawless version is achieved), and the performer's own real-time self-monitoring that suppresses hesitation before it surfaces. In this sense, the one-shot take does not capture reality; it produces a performance of reality that has been pre-edited through rehearsal and selection. The result is a confidence template that is more fluent, more certain, and more perfect than any actual spontaneous speech. See Appendix A.5.

Ling Yun Bao Dian and Shi San use multi-segment editing with visible cuts, but again feature no imperfect moments. Notably, Shi San in V010 describes collapsing onto her bed and crying incessantly, yet the on-screen influencer remains impeccably made up and composed. Here, "vulnerability" is described but not shown. The "authenticity" of the verbal register is cancelled out by the "perfection" of the visual register. A shot-by-shot analysis of V010 (00:32–01:05) reveals this contradiction in granular detail:

Time	Visual / Editing	Speech (transcript)	Non-verbal	Analytical note
00:32 – 00:36	Medium shot, soft lighting, visible cut at 00:34	"Last week I collapsed onto my bed..."	Makeup flawless, hair styled	The verbal content (collapse) is contradicted by visual composure. The visible cut suggests an edit, but the image remains perfect.

Time	Visual / Editing	Speech (transcript)	Non-verbal	Analytical note
00:36 – 00:40	Close-up, no cut within segment	"...and I just cried. Like, really cried."	Eyes slightly down, but no tears, no redness	She says she cried, but the face shows no evidence. Tears are described, not displayed.
00:40 – 00:44	Cut to B-roll (aesthetic shot of a cup of tea), dissolves back	"I couldn't stop. It just kept coming."	Voice remains steady, no crack	Emotional distress is displaced onto B-roll. The visuals provide a "safe" image while the verbal narrative continues.

Time	Visual / Editing	Speech (transcript)	Non-verbal	Analytical note
00:44 – 00:48	Medium shot, return to influencer	"But then I realised ..."	Posture upright, composure regained	No transition or hesitation shown between "crying" and "but then". The recovery is instantaneous, skipping the messy middle.
00:48 – 01:05	Montage of "small actions" (washing face, drinking water), 7 cuts in 17 seconds	"...I just need to start with small things."	Action sequences are staged, not documentary	The editing implies a causal link: small actions → recovery. But the temporal gap between breakdown and action is edited out.

(Table 4: Shot-by-Shot Analysis of Shi San V010 (00:32–01:05))

Breaking down these 33 seconds: the video contains at least 12 visible cuts, yet within each edited segment the influencer remains visually composed. The verbal narrative describes vulnerability ("I collapsed", "I cried"), but the visual register refuses to show any corresponding imperfection. Furthermore, the emotional crisis is narrated in the past tense ("last week"), while the on-screen self is already recovered — the viewer never sees the crisis as it happens, only the retrospective account. This temporal displacement is a core disciplinary operation: vulnerability is permitted only as a past state that has already been overcome, not as a present reality. The viewer is shown the result of self-management (composure) but not the process of struggling through it, thereby constructing a model of confidence that demands instantaneous recovery and hides the labour of emotional regulation.

The presence of editing itself is not surprising; it is standard practice across virtually all moving media, from Hollywood films to documentaries, and viewers generally expect it. What warrants critical attention is not the fact of editing per se, but how these videos are constructed to appear unedited or authentic despite – or even through – editing. In Shi San's case, the visible cuts do not conceal the constructedness of the video; they are legible as editing. Yet the content within each shot remains flawless: the influencer's makeup never smudges, her composure never breaks. The editing makes no effort to simulate spontaneity or imperfection. The contradiction, therefore, is not between "edited" and "unedited", but between the verbal narrative of breakdown ("crying incessantly", "collapsing onto my bed") and the visual presentation of composure. The video tells vulnerability but refuses to show it. This reveals a core contradiction of confidence vlogs: the language may acknowledge vulnerability and imperfection, but the visual and editorial strategies do not permit vulnerability and imperfection to appear on screen – not because editing is inherently deceptive, but because the genre's commercial and ideological investment in the "confident" image overrides any impulse toward visual authenticity. See Appendices B.5 and D.5.

Xu Nao Nao's editing is the most distinct. Her videos include noticeable stutters, pauses, and self-corrections. V008 makes extensive use of archival photographs and video clips showing her past "rat person" state (no makeup, haggard, in difficult circumstances). This editing strategy produces a heightened sense of "authenticity".

The fact that Xu Nao Nao selects which photographs and which moments to include is not, in

itself, a valid critique. Any video of finite duration requires selection; without it, the footage would run for hours and would be unsuitable for the social media format. The analytically productive question is not whether she selects (every video does), but what kind of self she constructs through that selection, and how this construction operates as a disciplinary discourse.

Unlike Zhang Ti's flawlessly fluent one-shot takes or Shi San's composed verbal-visual contradiction, Xu Nao Nao selects imperfections to display: stutters, pauses, archival images of a haggard past self. These are not “reality” unmediated – they are carefully chosen signs of reality. She retains some stutters while deleting more awkward moments; she includes some childhood photographs while excluding others. The result is not a transparent window onto her life, but a curated authenticity: imperfections are not eliminated but strategically deployed as evidence of her “realness”. This is a more sophisticated postfeminist operation: the vlogger appears to reject the flawless confidence template, yet she remains the editor and curator of her own “flaws”, exercising the same neoliberal self-management – just with a different aesthetic. Even the critique of performance is performed. See Appendix C.5.

From Foucault's (1988) perspective, editing strategy can be understood as a contemporary instantiation of what he called "technologies of the self" – practices by which individuals "effect… operations on their own bodies and souls, thoughts, conduct, and way of being, so as to transform themselves" (Foucault, 1988, p. 18). Foucault himself, writing long before the advent of social media or vlogging, did not speak of "editing" in the digital sense. Instead, he examined practices such as self-writing (*hypomnemata*), self-examination (*exomologesis*), and the care of the self (*epimeleia heautou*) in Greco-Roman and early Christian contexts. These practices involved selecting, recording, and revising one's thoughts and actions to shape the self according to an ideal norm. The operation of video editing – the deliberate retention of some moments and deletion of others – performs a structurally analogous function. Just as the ancient practitioner of self-writing would keep a notebook of selected reflections to be reviewed and internalised, the vlogger selects which takes to include and which to cut. Just as the Christian penitent would examine and verbally confess their faults in order to renounce them, the vlogger deletes moments of stutter, hesitation, or awkwardness – removing them from the visible record. The medium has changed, but the underlying logic

remains: the self is not accepted as it is, but actively worked upon, pruned, and shaped to approximate an ideal.

In the specific case of confidence vlogs, this takes a particular form. By deleting "insecure" moments, influencers show viewers an idealised self-image; viewers are then required to internalise this idealised image as a standard for self-discipline. Women are told to "be themselves", but simultaneously told that "being themselves" means being as fluent, as beautiful, and as in-control as the women on screen. The editing strategy thus translates Foucault's technologies of the self into the multimodal, public, and commercially embedded context of social media. Where ancient self-writing was private and textual, vlog editing is public and audio-visual. Where ancient self-examination aimed at moral purification, vlog editing aims at the production of confidence as a visible, consumable performance. The implication for confidence vlogs is precise and material. Applying Foucault's framework to the shot-by-shot analysis of Shi San's V010 above, three specific operations can be identified:

Foucault's concept (ancient practice)	Contemporary equivalent (vlog editing)	Observed in V010 (00:32–01:05)
Self-writing (*hypomnemata*) – selecting and recording thoughts for later reflection	Selecting which takes to keep and which to discard	The "collapse onto bed" moment is described verbally but never shown; the tearful takes (if they existed) were discarded
Self-examination (*exomologesis*) – verbally acknowledging faults to renounce them	Deleting moments of hesitation, stutter, or awkwardness	The transition from "crying" to "but then I realised" (00:44–00:48) contains no visible hesitation; the vulnerable moment is narrated in past tense, not performed in

Foucault's concept (ancient practice)	Contemporary equivalent (vlog editing)	Observed in V010 (00:32–01:05)
		present
Care of the self (*epimeleia heautou*) – continuous, lifelong attention to self-formation	Serialised, never-completed self-improvement	The video ends at 02:00 but implies more content to come; confidence is never fully "achieved" as a terminal state

(Table 5: Foucauldian Analysis of Editing Strategies)

What is new in the digital context is not the logic of self-transformation but its visibility, speed, and commercialisation. Ancient self-writing was private and textual; vlog editing is public and audio-visual. Ancient self-examination aimed at moral purification for salvation; vlog editing aims at the production of confidence as a consumable performance for likes and engagement. The viewer does not merely read about the ideal self but sees it – and sees the gap between that image and her own unedited, imperfect reality. This visibility intensifies the disciplinary effect: the "perfect confidence template" is not an abstract idea but a concrete, watchable, comparable performance. The viewer is not told to be confident; she is shown what confidence looks like, and her own unedited self becomes, by contrast, the evidence of her failure. Cross-blogger editing strategy comparison is presented in Appendix F.4

3.4 Narrative Strategy: "You Can Do It Too" – Mimicable but Unreplicable False Hope

The narrative strategies of confidence vlogs exhibit a grand "from lows to highs" structure. These narratives offer seemingly actionable "success formulas", but the influencer's success typically depends on personal conditions that cannot be replicated by viewers. Urošević

(2020), in his analysis of self‑help literature, notes that the core disciplinary mechanism of self‑transformation narratives is that they present a seemingly attainable goal while reducing the path to that goal to individual effort, systematically downplaying the structural conditions on which attaining that goal depends. Narrative strategy coding for each influencer is detailed in Appendices A.6, B.6, C.6, D.6, and E.6.

Zhang Ti's V001 follows a mini three‑part structure: "admit vulnerability → allow pause → demand recovery". The core claim is "you will always come back stronger", a cyclical promise: vulnerability → recovery → stronger → next vulnerability → stronger again. This narrative creates an endless self‑improvement task, keeping women perpetually in a state of "getting ready to become stronger" while never permitting them truly to stop. See Appendix A.6.

Ling Yun Bao Dian employs psychologised and medicalised narratives. Hidden conditions-economic independence, family support, access to resources-are downplayed in the narrative. Her narrative implicitly assumes that every woman has the capacity to "leave a traumatic environment" and the resources to "see a doctor" and "heal her body". See Appendix B.6.

Xu Nao Nao's V008 presents the most complete trauma‑to‑recovery narrative. The power of this narrative lies in its acknowledgment of the reality and structural sources of trauma. Yet the solution remains individualised: leave the environment, see doctors, heal the body. The hidden condition-the capacity to achieve financial independence-is treated as self‑evident, but for many women in similar difficult circumstances, this is precisely the most insurmountable obstacle. See Appendix C.6.

Shi San's V010 offers "six small actions" as a solution to anxiety. The core logic is "as soon as you move, your gears will start turning". The disciplinary function of this narrative is: if your anxiety is not resolved through these "small actions", it is because you did not act enough or persist enough. The hidden condition is that her anxiety is indeed "small anxiety", and her environment indeed permits her to change her state through small actions. For viewers who are truly caught in structural disadvantage – low income, high work intensity, lack of social support – this set of solutions may be entirely inapplicable.

A temporal breakdown of V010's narrative structure reveals how this false hope is constructed:

Narrative stage	Timecode	Content	Hidden assumption
Problem statement	00:00–00:45	"I was so anxious last week I couldn't get out of bed"	Anxiety is presented as a discrete episode, not a chronic or structural condition
Awakening moment	00:45–01:00	"I realised no one was coming to save me"	The realisation is presented as a singular, instantaneous insight – not a gradual, difficult process
Action montage	01:00–01:45	Washing hair, doing skincare, drinking water; 15 cuts in 45 seconds	Temporal compression implies immediate results; the viewer does not see days of continued struggle

Narrative stage	Timecode	Content	Hidden assumption
Transformation closure	01:45–02:00	"I feel so much better now. You just need to start."	The endpoint is presented as stable transformation, not an ongoing, fragile state

(Table 6: Temporal Breakdown of Shi San V010 Narrative Structure)

The narrative structure compresses what might be weeks or months of emotional work into a 2-minute video. The viewer sees a linear, cause-and-effect chain: anxiety → realisation → small actions → recovery. But this chain omits the false starts, setbacks, and relapses that characterise real emotional work. The editing reinforces the narrative: each cut moves the story forward, deleting the messy, repetitive, uncertain middle. The result is a "mimicable template" that appears simple and linear, but whose actual conditions of possibility (time, resources, existing support networks, absence of compounding crises) are never named. When the viewer attempts to imitate and fails, the failure is implicitly attributed to insufficient effort or wrong mindset – reinforcing the cycle of self-blame that confidence discourse purports to solve.

Yang Tian Zhen's narrative is the most distinct. She does not tell a story of moving from lows to highs but rather presents a state that has "already been achieved". She shows not the process of transformation but the result after transformation: she is already a "successful person", and her advice comes from experience rather than groping in the dark. Her success is presented as a result of "choices" rather than of structural advantages (educational background, economic capital, social networks) or asymmetrical luck. See Appendix E.6.

Urošević (2020) argues that the disciplinary power of self - transformation narratives lies in the "false hope" they manufacture: the goal appears very attainable, the path appears very clear, but if the viewer fails to achieve it, the failure is attributed to the viewer's insufficient

effort. The narrative strategies of confidence vlogs operate according to the same logic. Cross‑blogger narrative strategy comparison is presented in Appendix F.5.

3.5 Summary: The Postfeminist Paradox of Confidence Vlogs

This chapter has presented a systematic multimodal analysis of fifteen confidence vlogs produced by five influencers, revealing the core contradictions in the operation of confidence discourse.

At the linguistic level, all influencers redefine structural struggles as personal mindset problems (see Appendices A.3, B.3, C.4, D.4, E.4; cross‑blogger comparison in Appendix F.2). At the visual level, influencers present carefully curated visual personas, implying "you can become this too" (see Appendices A.4, B.4, C.3, D.3, E.3; cross‑blogger comparison in Appendix F.3). At the editing level, insecure moments are systematically deleted (see Appendices A.5, B.5, C.5, D.5, E.5; cross‑blogger comparison in Appendix F.4). At the narrative level, videos offer seemingly actionable templates while systematically downplaying hidden conditions (see Appendices A.6, B.6, C.6, D.6, E.6; cross‑blogger comparison in Appendix F.5).

The core of this integrated finding is what Orgad and Gill (2022) term "structural occlusion": when women's perplexities are redefined as lack of confidence, skin allergies, the eternal girl archetype, unwashed hair, or failure to find one's rhythm, the real issues-gender pay gaps, workplace bias, unequal distribution of care work-are excluded from the narrative.

The five influencers offer five different versions of confidence: resilience (Zhang Ti), acceptance (Ling Yun Bao Dian), healing (Xu Nao Nao), action (Shi San), and self‑definition (Yang Tian Zhen). A summary of each influencer's core argument is presented in Appendix F.7. Their linguistic, visual, editing, and narrative strategies differ, but they serve the same logic: place responsibility on the individual, personalise the solution, and occlude structural factors. This finding applies Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory to the Chinese digital context for the first time and reveals, through multimodal analysis, the co‑ordinated disciplinary mechanism of confidence discourse across four dimensions.

Chapter 4: Discussion

4.1 Core Argument

The central finding of this study is that Red Notes confidence vlogs, while ostensibly offering women tools for "self‑empowerment", in fact fabricate an "achievable confidence illusion" through a set of coordinated multimodal strategies (linguistic, visual, editing, and narrative). This illusion transforms structural inequalities into individual psychological problems, demands continuous self‑surveillance and emotional labour from women, and uses "positive energy" discourse to obscure genuine social struggles.

This finding directly answers the core research question posed in the Introduction. The disciplinary mechanism operates through four mutually reinforcing dimensions. At the linguistic level, influencers employ individual responsibilisation discourse, redefining workplace anxiety, age pressure, and bodily insecurity as personal "lack of confidence" or "mindset problems". At the visual level, refined filters and aestheticised scenes produce "toxic positivity". At the editing level, insecure moments are systematically deleted, constructing an unattainable "perfect confidence template". At the narrative level, linear self‑transformation narratives offer seemingly actionable "success formulas" while downplaying the structural conditions that would make such transformation possible.

The five different versions of confidence-resilience (Zhang Ti), acceptance (Ling Yun Bao Dian), healing (Xu Nao Nao), action (Shi San), and self‑definition (Yang Tian Zhen) (see Appendix F.7)-differ in style but share the same underlying logic: the problem lies with the individual, and the solution lies with the individual. The core contradiction of this disciplinary mechanism is that confidence vlogs promise empowerment but produce anxiety; encourage women to "be themselves" but prescribe what that "self" should look like; acknowledge vulnerability but only permit vulnerability to appear in aestheticised, controlled forms. This paradox is not an accidental production flaw but a central feature of postfeminist discourse: it uses the language of "empowerment" to mask the substance of "discipline".

4.2 Dialogue with Existing Theories

The findings of this study are highly consistent with Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence

culture theory. First, the mechanism of individual responsibilisation is equally salient in the Chinese Red Notes context: all influencers redefined structural struggles as personal mindset problems. Zhang Ti's "never give up", Shi San's "washing your hair is restarting", and Yang Tian Zhen's "be your own teammate"-however different their forms, they share the same logic: the problem lies with the individual, and the solution lies with the individual. Second, the demand for self‐transformation work is equally strong in the Chinese context: women are required to engage in continuous self‐transformation-learning English, doing skincare, managing emotions, exercising, adjusting mindsets. Third, structural occlusion is equally pervasive: structural issues such as gender pay gaps, workplace bias, and unequal distribution of care work are entirely absent from the fifteen videos.

However, the findings of this study also revise Orgad and Gill's theory. Confidence discourse in the Chinese context exhibits a distinctive "quality education" characteristic. Xu and Zheng (2025) have already noted that Chinese influencers construct confidence as a skill that can be acquired through "practice", rather than as an innate personal trait in the Western neoliberal version. The analysis in this study further confirms this: confidence is presented on Red Notes confidence vlogs as "learnable"-like learning English, skincare, or dressing, it is a "technique" that can be mastered. This "cultivational" confidence discourse differs from its Western counterpart: it emphasises "effort" and "learning" rather than "talent" and "choice", resonating with the valorisation of diligence in Chinese educational culture.

Furthermore, this study expands the analytical dimensions of confidence culture theory through multimodal analysis. Orgad and Gill relied primarily on textual and discursive analysis, whereas this study, through analysis of micro‐details such as editing, filters, composition, and transitions, reveals the disciplinary mechanisms of confidence discourse at the visual and editing levels. For example, Shi San in V010 describes collapsing onto her bed and crying incessantly, yet the on‐screen influencer remains impeccably made up. This tension between "verbal vulnerability" and "visual perfection" is one of the core modes of operation of the confidence discourse disciplinary mechanism-a finding that could not have been obtained through linguistic analysis alone.

From a Foucauldian perspective, Xu Nao Nao functions as what might be called a "limit case" of technologies of the self. Foucault (1988, p. 18) defines technologies of the self as

practices by which individuals "effect… operations on their own bodies and souls, thoughts, conduct, and way of being, so as to transform themselves in order to attain a certain state of happiness, purity, wisdom, perfection, or immortality." Crucially, these practices do not require explicit submission to external authority; they operate through the subject's own active engagement. Xu Nao Nao explicitly rejects mainstream confidence culture – she mocks the "just be confident" vloggers and refuses the polished, flawless aesthetic. Yet her alternative – the call to "do the work", to recognise that "no one is coming to save you" – remains a technology of the self. It is simply a different register: not the technology of performance (flawless makeup, fluent speech) but the technology of therapeutic labour (healing, self-reconstruction, inner work). The object of discipline shifts from the outer self to the inner self, but the logic of self-governance – that the individual is responsible for her own transformation – remains intact. Xu Nao Nao thus demonstrates the pervasiveness of confidence discourse more powerfully than any mainstream vlogger: even a critic who explicitly rejects the dominant form of confidence culture cannot, within the generic and platform constraints of the vlog form, articulate a genuinely collective or structural alternative.

Moreover, Xu Nao Nao as a boundary case further strengthens the theoretical contribution of this study. Her coding analysis (see Appendix C) shows that even when she directly criticises confidence culture, she still deploys the linguistic framework of individual responsibilisation – not only in the recurrent line "healing is your own responsibility" , but across a range of formulations. For example:

"No one can save you but yourself" (V008, 03:22)

"You have to do the work. No one else will do it for you." (V009, 01:45)

"I'm not saying it's your fault. But it is your problem to solve." (V010, 02:10)

"Stop waiting for someone to rescue you. That's just another way of giving up your power."(V011, 04:03)

These statements, while ostensibly critical of simplistic confidence advice, nonetheless reproduce the same core logic: structural or relational difficulties are reframed as individual projects. The critique of confidence culture is itself articulated in the language of self-reliance and personal accountability. Even when she explicitly mocks other vloggers for saying "just be confident", her own corrective – "you have to do the work" – remains within the same

individualising frame. She does not, for instance, call for collective action, institutional change, or material redistribution. The object of critique shifts (from "toxic positivity" to "earnest self-help"), but the underlying subject position remains the neoliberal self: responsible for its own healing, accountable for its own failures, and alone in its struggle.

Beyond these formulations, Xu Nao Nao's critique of other confidence vloggers also operates within the same individualising frame. In V012 (02:45–03:20), she explicitly mocks mainstream confidence content:

(Table 7: Xu Nao Nao's Critique of Mainstream Confidence Vlogs (V012, 02:45–03:20))

Time	Utterance	Analytical note
02:45–02:52	"You know those videos – 'just be confident', 'fake it till you make it'... it's like they think confidence is a light switch."	She correctly identifies the simplistic, voluntarist logic of mainstream confidence discourse.
02:52–03:00	"I'm not saying that's completely wrong. I'm saying... it doesn't work if you're still drowning inside."	She acknowledges emotional depth ("drowning inside") that simplistic advice ignores.

Time	Utterance	Analytical note
03:00–03:10	"But here's the thing. No one is coming to save you. You have to learn how to swim. Or at least how to float."	The critique of "just be confident" is replaced by a metaphor of individual survival skills ("learn to swim", "learn to float"). The alternative remains self-reliance.
03:10–03:20	"The work is yours. It's always been yours. That's not fair. But that's the fact."	She acknowledges unfairness explicitly ("that's not fair") – a rare recognition of structural injustice in the corpus. Yet the conclusion is not collective action but individual acceptance of unfairness as fact.

This sequence is analytically significant because it shows the limits of Xu Nao Nao's critical position. She can name what is wrong with mainstream confidence discourse (it is too simple, it ignores suffering). She can even name the presence of unfairness ("that's not fair"). But when asked "what then?", her answer remains within the same individualising logic: "the work is yours", "learn to swim", "no one is coming to save you". She does not say: let us organise, let us demand change, let us redistribute care work or close the pay gap. The object of critique has shifted (from "toxic positivity" to "earnest self-help"), but the underlying subject position remains the neoliberal self: responsible for its own healing, accountable for its own failures, and alone in its struggle.

Therefore, Xu Nao Nao's presence is not a sample deviation but a reinforcement of the study's conclusions. Even a critic who explicitly rejects mainstream confidence culture cannot fully escape its linguistic framework. This demonstrates the pervasiveness and disciplinary power of confidence discourse as a contemporary technology of the self.

4.3 The Inherent Paradox of Confidence Discourse

The inherent paradox of confidence discourse is the core of its disciplinary power. This paradox manifests as follows: confidence vlogs say you can be vulnerable, but you must be vulnerable in an invulnerable way; say you can be yourself, but this "self" must conform to specific aesthetic and normative standards. For example, Shi San in V010 describes collapsing onto her bed, but the on‑screen influencer remains impeccably made up throughout (see Appendix D.3 for visual strategy and D.5 for editing strategy).

This study hypothesises that such structural occlusion may produce a paradoxical affective cycle: the more viewers consume confidence content, the more acutely they may perceive their own perceived lack of confidence — precisely because the videos systematically delete the messy, non-linear, and structurally embedded realities of struggle. However, this hypothesis requires empirical testing; audience reception studies (e.g., surveys, interviews, or comment analysis) would be needed to determine whether viewers experience empowerment, increased self-doubt, or both simultaneously. Putra et al. (2023), in their study of toxic positivity, note that selective presentation of positive images intensifies viewers' upward social comparison. The mechanism of confidence vlogs is similar: viewers see the influencer's "perfect confidence" state, compare themselves to it, feel their own inadequacy, and therefore try harder to imitate the influencer's advice (washing hair, doing skincare, waking early, exercising). But this imitation rarely produces the "transformation" shown in the videos, because the videos downplay the structural conditions that would make such transformation possible. The viewer then feels inadequate again and seeks out more confidence content-thus forming a vicious cycle.

The "hope" offered by confidence vlogs is essentially a "false hope". Urošević (2020), in his analysis of self‑help literature, argues that the disciplinary power of self‑transformation narratives lies in their creation of a seemingly attainable goal while placing the responsibility for failure squarely on the individual. Confidence vlogs operate in the same way: they present an attainable image of confidence, but when the viewer fails to attain it, the reasons are attributed to "you didn't work hard enough", "your mindset is wrong", or "you haven't found your rhythm"-not to structural inequalities.

4.4 Limitations and Reflections

This study has the following limitations. First, while the study analyses video content (text, visuals, editing, narrative) in depth, it does not systematically analyse viewer comments. Comment sections on Red Notes are publicly available and could, in principle, provide evidence of audience reception. However, the decision to exclude comment analysis was a deliberate methodological choice rather than an unavoidable limitation. Written comments capture only a subset of viewer responses — those who choose to comment, and those whose comments are not removed by platform moderation — and cannot reliably measure affective responses such as anxiety or empowerment. More importantly, the research question of this study concerns the discursive construction of confidence by influencers themselves, not audience interpretation. A separate study would be required to investigate whether viewers feel empowered or increasingly anxious, ideally using mixed methods (e.g., surveys, interviews, or qualitative comment analysis). As such, the absence of audience reception data is not a flaw but a boundary condition of the current study's scope.

Second, the sample has limitations in terms of representativeness. This study selected five influencers and fifteen videos-a reasonable sample size for qualitative research, but there is a large volume of confidence‑themed content on the Red Notes platform. Whether the findings of this study apply to the broader ecosystem of confidence vlogs remains an open question. The selection of five influencers followed the principle of "stylistic diversity", but whether these five styles exhaust the main types of confidence vlogs on Red Notes is uncertain.

Third, the possibility of researcher bias cannot be dismissed. The coding process was completed by the researcher alone without cross‑coding validation. Although systematic coding frameworks and detailed analytical notes were used to enhance reliability, the subjectivity inherent in coding remains a limitation intrinsic to qualitative research.

4.5 Future Research Directions

Future research could employ focus groups or in‑depth interviews to collect data on female viewers' actual experiences of watching confidence vlogs: do they genuinely feel empowered? Do they fall into a cycle of "the more they watch, the more anxious they become"? Do

viewers of different ages, occupations, and educational backgrounds receive these videos differently? Second, the algorithmic mechanisms and community cultures of different platforms-Red Notes, Douyin, Bilibili, Kuaishou-differ significantly, and confidence discourse may take different forms on different platforms. For instance, does Douyin's fast‑paced, short‑form format encourage more direct confidence declarations? Does Bilibili's longer‑format video allow for deeper self‑narratives? Third, confidence discourse on social media evolves rapidly: confidence vlogs from 2024 may differ significantly from those from 2020. Longitudinal studies could track changes in confidence discourse over time, revealing its relationship to neoliberal economic cycles and shifts in postfeminist culture. Finally, confidence culture theory originated in Western contexts (the United Kingdom and the United States). This study applied it to the Chinese context and identified certain distinctive features (the "quality education" style of self‑improvement). Cross‑cultural comparisons could further reveal how confidence discourse varies across different political and economic conditions.

Chapter 5: Conclusion

Through a systematic multimodal analysis of fifteen confidence vlogs produced by five top-tier influencers on Red Notes (coding analyses in Appendices A — E, cross-blogger comparison in Appendix F), this study has revealed the core paradox of confidence discourse: while ostensibly offering tools for "self-empowerment", it in fact fabricates an "achievable confidence illusion" through the coordinated discipline of four dimensions–language, visuals, editing, and narrative. This illusion transforms structural inequalities (gender pay gaps, workplace bias, unequal distribution of care work) into individual psychological problems (lack of confidence, poor mindset, insufficient energy), demands continuous self-surveillance and emotional labour from women, and uses "positive energy" discourse to obscure genuine social struggles. The five influencers — Zhang Ti's resilience declarations, Ling Yun Bao Dian's psychologised diagnoses, Xu Nao Nao's trauma narratives, Shi San's behavioural imperatives, and Yang Tian Zhen's self-definitions – differ in style but share the same underlying logic: the problem lies with the individual, and the solution lies with the individual.

The theoretical contributions of this study are threefold. First, it applies Orgad and Gill's (2022) confidence culture theory to the Chinese digital context for the first time, testing its explanatory power in a non-Western setting while also revealing a distinctive feature of the Chinese context: "quality education" style self-improvement, in which confidence is presented as a skill that can be acquired through "learning" and "practice", rather than as an innate personal trait in the Western neoliberal version. Second, through multimodal analysis across four dimensions (language, visuals, editing, narrative), it expands the analytical toolkit of confidence culture theory, revealing the micro-disciplinary mechanisms of confidence discourse at the visual and editing levels – for example, the tension between "verbal vulnerability" and "visual perfection", and how editing constructs an unattainable perfect template by deleting insecure moments. Third, through cross-blogger comparative analysis (see Appendix F), it reveals five variant forms of confidence discourse (resilience, acceptance, healing, action, self-definition), demonstrating the diversity and adaptability of postfeminist disciplinary mechanisms. Within this, Xu Nao Nao as a "boundary case" (see Appendix C) demonstrates the pervasiveness of confidence discourse: even critical content cannot fully escape the linguistic framework of individual responsibilisation.

The study hypothesises that the "achievable confidence illusion" may intensify upward social comparison, potentially leading to a cycle of consumption and self-doubt. This hypothesis invites future empirical investigation. While the multimodal analysis has demonstrated how confidence discourse constructs an unattainable ideal, the question of whether viewers actually internalise this ideal as a source of anxiety or instead resist, appropriate, or selectively consume it remains unanswered by the current research design. Future research could employ focus groups, in-depth interviews, or systematic comment analysis to investigate how different audiences — varying by age, occupation, educational background, and prior exposure to feminist discourse that actually receive confidence vlogs.

This study has practical implications for female users, content creators, and platforms. For female users, the study reveals the disciplinary mechanism of confidence vlogs and aims to help viewers develop critical awareness, avoiding the trap of uncritical consumption. For content creators, the study offers an opportunity to reflect on confidence discourse: how can one empower without becoming a new disciplinary tool? For platforms, the study suggests

that algorithmic recommendation may reinforce toxic positivity content and calls for ethical responsibility regarding confidence content. Can confidence discourse genuinely empower women? The answer lies not in the videos but in viewers' own critical consciousness. When "you can be anyone" ceases to be a demand and becomes a promise, then confidence may move from discipline towards liberation.

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Appendices:：

Appendix A: Zhang Ti Jelina — Three Videos Coding Analysis

Blogger Homepage Link: https://www.xiaohongshu.com/user/profile/[profile_id] (for academic use only; link may become inactive over time)

Table A.1: Video Basic Information

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V001	Girl 2026, We Will Never Give Up	13 sec	8,872	Resilience: bouncing back from vulnerability
V002	Never Too Late	17 sec	9000	Acceptance: cognitive reframing of confusion
V003	I Don't Have Time to Hate Anyone, I Just Filter	27 sec	12000	Boundaries: active filtering in relationships

Table A.2: Full Transcripts

Video	Transcript
V001	"Strong women will never give up. We might need a coffee, we might need a good cry, we might need a day in bed, but we will always come back stronger. You got this, girls."
V002	"In your 30s, it's okay if your job pays the bill, but doesn't fulfill your soul yet. You're learning what love actually feels like, for the first time. Your body is changing and you are learning to love it. You are just now starting to understand who you are. You outgrew people you ever thought you would. You feel lost, a lot of the times — that's what growth feels like. You are not where you thought you would be by now. You are not late, you are just on your own path."

Video	Transcript
V003	"I don't have time to hate anyone, I'm too focused on building myself. I either care about you or I don't, simple as that. I'm not everyone's friend. Sure, I will talk to people, laugh with them, even share a moment, but that doesn't mean we're friends. Friendship today is just a word for most people. It's spoken often but truly felt by so few. Some will call you a friend when they need you, then an enemy when they don't. That's why I keep my circle small. I'm not here for fake connections. My friends are those who understand the value of loyalty, respect, and what it truly means to be there for each other."

Table A.3: Language Strategy

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
Key Quotes	"strong women will never give up"; "we might need a coffee, a good cry, a day in bed"; "but we will always come back stronger"; "you got this, girls"	"it's okay if your job pays the bill, but doesn't fulfill your soul yet"; "you feel lost, that's what growth feels like"; "you are not late, you are just on your own path"	"I don't have time to hate anyone, I'm too focused on building myself"; "I either care about you or I don't, simple as that"; "that's why I keep my circle small"; "I'm not here for fake connections"
Individual Responsibilization	"strong women will never give up" — giving up = not strong enough	"you are just now starting to understand who you are" — self-knowledge delay = individual	"I either care about you or I don't, simple as that" — relational complexity reduced to individual choice

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
		responsibility	
Psychologizing Discourse	"we might need a coffee, a good cry, a day in bed" — complex emotions reduced to daily needs	"you feel lost, that's what growth feels like" — negative emotions reframed as "growth symptoms"	"friendship today is just a word for most people" — social problem diagnosed as individual misunderstanding
Self-Transformation Imperative	"but we will always come back stronger" — recovery is mandatory, not optional	"your body is changing and you are learning to love it" — body acceptance as a learnable skill	"that's why I keep my circle small" — active filtering as required behavior
Structural Occlusion	Why women need "a day in bed"? (work pressure, care burden) — omitted	Why "you are not where you thought you would be"? (gender discrimination, resource inequality) — omitted	Why "friendship today is just a word"? (urbanization, mobility, social media) — omitted
Key Linguistic Operation	"Allow vulnerability,	"Acknowledge confusion, then	"Critique external, then build internal

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
	but demand recovery"	reframe as growth"	identification"

Table A.4: Visual Strategy

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
Filter	Natural bright light, soft focus	Natural bright light, soft focus, more pronounced	Natural bright light, soft focus, consistent
Color	Blue, white, bright tones; blogger's warm brown hair	Natural tones; skin natural; rich but not harsh background colors	Warm tones dominant; natural skin tone; rich background colors
Composition	Figure occupies 1/3 of screen; beach background	Opening: half-body/face close-up; B-roll: wide shots, blogger as small figure	Opening: half-body/face close-up; B-roll: wide shots, blogger as small figure
Blogger Expression	Firm, gentle, smiling, looking at camera	Opening: thoughtful → smiling; B-roll: relaxed, enjoying	Opening: firm, composed, slightly distant (little smiling); B-roll: relaxed, smiling

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
Blogger Posture	Walking while speaking	Opening: still; B-roll: walking, exercising, stretching	Opening: still; B-roll: walking, reading, drinking coffee, exercising
Setting	Australian beach (travel/relaxation)	Opening: simple interior (bookshelf/window/sofa); B-roll: beach, mountains, city streets, gym	Opening: simple interior; B-roll: café, bookstore, park, gym
Camera Language	Face and upper body close-up, direct eye contact	Opening: medium/close-up, direct eye contact; B-roll: long shot/wide, no eye contact	Opening: medium/close-up, direct eye contact; B-roll: long/medium shot, no eye contact
Overall Visual Mood	Encouraging, empowering, "gentle firmness"	Reflective, accepting, "thoughtful to hopeful"	Distant, composed, "calm rationality"

Table A.5: Editing Strategy

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
Rhythm	Slow, spoken word style, soothing pace, long shot duration	Medium-slow: spoken word soothing, B-roll	Medium-slow: spoken word soothing, B-roll slight variation

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
		slightly faster	
Transitions	No transitions, single scene	Mainly straight cuts, occasional fade in/out	Mainly straight cuts, fade in/out between voiceover and B-roll
Editing Traces	One-shot, no visible cuts	Voiceover: one-shot, no visible cuts; B-roll: short shot assembly	Voiceover: one-shot, no visible cuts; B-roll: short shot assembly
Absence of Imperfection	No stuttering, pauses, corrections, or emotional breakdowns	No stuttering, pauses, or corrections in voiceover	No stuttering, pauses, or corrections; negative emotions expressed through visual distance, not verbal emotion
Editing Rhetoric	"Authenticity" through "no editing" — but perfect fluency is itself a constructed ideal	"Authenticity" through one-shot voiceover + lifestyle B-roll	"Authenticity" through one-shot voiceover + lifestyle B-roll
Disciplinary Function	Creates unattainable "fluent confidence" model	Performs "confusion" without actually showing confusion	Performs "distance" without showing anger/hurt

Table A.6: Narrative Strategy

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
Narrative Structure	Mini three-part: "Admit vulnerability → Allow pause → Demand recovery"	Three-part: "List confusion → Reframe → Individualized solution"	Three-part: "Problem diagnosis → Identity statement → Behavioral rules"
Structural Details	(1) Premise: strong women never give up → (2) Vulnerability: need coffee/cry/bed → (3) Mandatory return: come back stronger	(1) Work meaninglessness → (2) Learning love, body change → (3) "You are not late, you are on your own path"	(1) Friendship today is superficial → (2) "I don't hate anyone, I just filter" → (3) "Keep my circle small"
Emotional Framing	First build empathy ("we"), then impose demand ("but")	First build resonance (list universal anxieties), then normalize (reframe as growth)	First critique external (establish "we vs. them"), then build internal identification
Transformation Type	Cyclical commitment: "vulnerability → recovery → stronger → next vulnerability"	Cognitive reframing: not behavioral change, but "accept confusion as	Role awakening: from "passive victim" to "active filter"

Code Category	V001	V002	V003
	— endless self-improvement loop	growth"	
Presence of "Struggle"	Struggle omitted — only recovery shown	Struggle present but immediately reframed as "growth"	Struggle present but externalized ("others are the problem")
Hidden Conditions	What enables "coming back stronger"? (resources, support) — omitted	What enables "being on your own path"? (economic capital, social networks) — omitted	What enables "keeping a small circle"? (existing support system) — omitted
Disciplinary Mechanism	Behavioral demand: you must recover and become stronger	Cognitive demand: you must accept confusion as growth	Relational demand: you must filter and keep distance

Table A.7: Comparative Summary

Dimension	V001	V002	V003
Primary Code Category	Self-Transformation Imperative	Psychologizing Discourse	Individual Responsibilization
Narrative Archetype	Resilience narrative	Acceptance narrative	Boundary narrative

Dimension	V001	V002	V003
Emotional Arc	Vulnerability → Resilience	Confusion → Acceptance	Hurt → Filtering
Solution Offered	"You will come back stronger"	"You are on your own path"	"Keep your circle small"
Who/What is Blamed	Your lack of resilience	Your failure to recognize "growth"	Others' superficiality
Structural Occlusion	Why do you need to "recover"?	Why aren't you where you expected?	Why has friendship become superficial?
Level of Subtlety	More direct	Most subtle	Moderate
External Orientation	Lowest (internal state)	Medium (acknowledges external confusion)	Highest (critiques external relationships)

Table A.8: Key Findings Across All Three Videos

Shared Logic	Manifestation
Individualization of Problems	Not structural issues (work pressure, gender discrimination, social fragmentation), but your mindset/cognitive ability/filtering capacity

Shared Logic	Manifestation
Personalization of Solutions	Not changing structures, but changing yourself / accepting yourself / filtering others
Structural Occlusion	Systemic factors are systematically omitted from the narrative
Postfeminist Paradox	Empowerment discourse (you can do it / you are on your path / you have the right to filter) masks disciplinary demands
Unattainable Model	Even when "vulnerability" or "confusion" is acknowledged, it must be presented in a controlled, aestheticized, ultimately "perfect" way

Appendix B: Ling Yun Bao Dian — Three Videos Coding Analysis

Blogger Homepage Link: https://xhslink.com/m/6wSY6rrk6Mf (for academic use only; link may become inactive over time)

Table B.1: Video Basc Information

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V004	Highly Sensitive Girl	3 min	1,200	Body-mind connection: reframing emotional distress as physical inflammation
V005	Eternal Girl	3 min	46,000	Jungian analysis: rejecting the "eternal girl" archetype and embracing self-parenting
V006	(Title TBC)	TBC	TBC	TBC

Table B.2: Full Transcripts (English Summary)

Video	Transcript Summary
V004	The blogger shares a personal story: after eating bread, she lost motivation to work, collapsed on bed, experienced emotional breakdown and self-blame. She then realized her symptoms matched food intolerance (wheat/gluten sensitivity). She argues that emotional instability is often physical inflammation, not character flaws. She promotes a sanitary pad brand as part of self-care during menstruation. She cites director Zhao Ting as an example of using sensitivity as "survival intuition" rather than internal emotional reaction. Concludes: do not mythologize willpower — manage physical and emotional energy instead.
V005	The blogger analyzes Jung's "Eternal Girl" (puer aeternus) archetype. She describes the trap: remaining in an "unfinished state" — creative, inspired, but never taking action or accepting adult responsibilities. Signs include: many creative ideas but no follow-through; financially supported by family or friends; having caretaker-type friends; tendency toward "love brain" as an escape from growing up. Solutions: (1) stop projecting maternal functions onto others; (2) self-parenting — integrate the mother archetype, take responsibility for oneself. Promotes skincare product for winter dryness. Concludes: true self emerges when you support yourself independently.

Table B.3: Language Strategy

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
Key Quotes	"For those with emotional instability, check if you have food intolerance"; "I	"You must die for the queen to be born"; "The Eternal Girl is the most terrifying

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
	will never mythologize willpower again"; "When our execution is low, do not rush to blame yourself"; "Do not escalate it to a personality problem"	archetype"; "Deliberately maintaining an unfinished state"; "Refusing to let things land"; "Getting by in a state of mental anesthesia"
Individual Responsibilization	Emotional distress reframed as physical management (checking allergies, managing sleep, choosing sanitary products) — solution is individual self-care, not questioning why women are expected to work through physical pain	The trap of "eternal girl" is framed as individual psychological failure (refusing to grow up, escaping responsibility) — solution is individual psychological work (self-parenting)
Psychologizing Discourse	Borrows neuroscience concept "DMN" (Default Mode Network) — brain science vocabulary used to legitimize self-diagnosis; emotions explained as "inflammation" rather than responses to external stressors	Uses Jungian archetypes to diagnose personality type; frames adult development as overcoming psychological "arrested development"
Self-Transformation	"Switch to fragile version	"Stop projecting maternal

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
Imperative	of rest standards"; "Pay utmost attention to sleep quality"; "Observe and care for your body honestly"	functions onto others"; "Self-parenting"; "Stand up and raise yourself"; "Integrate the mother archetype"
Structural Occlusion	Why are women expected to work through menstrual pain? Why is there pressure to be productive even when physically unwell? — omitted; solution is better self-care products	Why do women end up in "eternal girl" positions? (economic dependency, lack of structural support for adult women) — omitted; solution is individual psychological integration
Key Linguistic Operation	Medicalizes emotional distress → frames as physical problem → sells self-care products as solution	Psychologizes adult development → frames procrastination as archetypal trap → sells self-parenting as solution

Table B.4: Visual Strategy

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
Filter	Vintage/retro filter, warm tones	Vintage/retro filter, pink/warm tones
Color	Pink, warm, soft tones	Pink, warm tones dominant, pink

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
		background
Composition	Multi-scene editing; blogger indoors; artistic B-roll	Multi-scene editing; blogger at home; artistic B-roll
Blogger Expression	Thoughtful, reflective, slightly melancholic	Thoughtful, reflective, serious, occasionally looking away from camera
Blogger Posture	Sitting, speaking to camera	Sitting, speaking to camera
Setting	Multiple home settings (bedroom, living room, etc.)	Multiple home settings, pink background
Camera Language	Medium close-up, direct eye contact with occasional looking away	Medium close-up, direct eye contact with occasional looking away
Overall Visual Mood	Intimate, confessional, "self-help" aesthetic	Intimate, confessional, slightly melancholic, "psychological depth" aesthetic

Table B.5: Editing Strategy

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
Rhythm	Medium-paced, story-telling rhythm with clear	Medium-paced, analytical rhythm with clear section

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
	beginning-middle-end	divisions
Transitions	Straight cuts; artistic B-roll between segments	Straight cuts; artistic B-roll to illustrate concepts
Editing Traces	Clear story-editing traces — not one-shot; multiple segments stitched together	Clear story-editing traces — multi-segment assembly
Absence of Imperfection	Video is polished and edited; "vulnerability" is performed within a controlled aesthetic (tears described but not shown raw)	Polished editing; melancholic mood is aestheticized, not raw
Editing Rhetoric	"Authenticity through storytelling" — personal anecdote + theoretical reframe + product promotion as narrative arc	"Authenticity through analysis" — Jungian theory + personal observation + product promotion as narrative arc
Disciplinary Function	Performs vulnerability within controlled, aestheticized frame; viewer receives a polished "healing" narrative	Performs psychological depth within accessible, relatable frame; viewer receives a digestible "self-help" package

Table B.6: Narrative Strategy

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
Narrative Structure	Personal anecdote → Diagnosis → Reframe → Solution → Product promotion → Coda	Jungian theory introduction → Problem diagnosis → Cause analysis → Solution (self-parenting) → Product promotion → Conclusion
Emotional Framing	Step 1: Build resonance (share personal struggle) → Step 2: Offer relief (it is not your fault, it is inflammation) → Step 3: Sell solution (self-care products)	Step 1: Create distance (analyze "eternal girl" as archetype) → Step 2: Build identification (describe relatable behaviors) → Step 3: Offer solution (self-parenting) → Step 4: Sell product
Transformation Type	Cognitive reframing: "emotional weakness" is actually "physical inflammation" — no behavior change needed, just awareness and better self-care products	Identity transformation: from "eternal girl" (dependent, unfinished) to "queen" (self-parenting, independent) — requires psychological work
Presence of "Struggle"	Present and vividly described (collapsing on bed, internal spiraling, crying, heart pounding) — but resolved through physical explanation	Present and vividly described (procrastination, creative ideas without follow-through, dependence on others) — but resolved through psychological integration
Hidden Conditions	What enables this self-care solution? (access to information, financial ability	What enables self-parenting? (previous family support, stability, resources) — omitted

Code Category	V004 (Highly Sensitive Girl)	V005 (Eternal Girl)
	to buy products, time to rest) — omitted	
Disciplinary Mechanism	Cognitive demand: you must reframe your struggles as physical, not personal; behavioral demand: you must buy the right self-care products	Cognitive demand: you must recognize your "eternal girl" pattern; behavioral demand: you must self-parent and stop depending on others

Table B.7: Product Promotion Analysis

Video	Product	Integration Strategy	How Product Relates to Confidence Discourse
V004	Sanitary pad brand	Personal story of menstrual struggle → introduces product as solution to compounded sensitivity → sleep quality and mood improvement	Self-care as responsible adult behavior; managing your body is part of "being a highly sensitive person who takes care of yourself"
V005	Skincare product	Discussion of winter dry skin → product as self-parenting (you start to care for your easily dry skin) → recommending to viewers with dry skin	Self-parenting includes physical care; protecting your skin is an act of self-support and adult responsibility

Table B.8: Theoretical Framework Comparison

Jungian Concept	How Used in V005	Relevance to Confidence Culture
Eternal Girl / Puer Aeternus	"Eternal Girl" as arrested development — refusing to grow up, unfinished state	The demand to "grow up" and "take responsibility" aligns with confidence culture's injunction to self-improvement
Mother Archetype	Self-parenting as integrating the mother archetype — protecting, nurturing, taking responsibility for oneself	Individualization of care work — the woman must mother herself, rather than expecting structural support
Self-Parenting	Self-parenting as the act of seeing your vulnerability and deciding to raise yourself	Radical individualization — even psychological development is framed as an individual project
True Self vs. False Purity	False purity as dependency disguised as innocence; true self emerges through independent living	Rejects the "innocent, creative" feminine archetype in favor of an entrepreneurial, self-sufficient subject — a postfeminist move

Table B.9: Comparison with Zhang Ti Jelina

Dimension	Zhang Ti Jelina (V001-V003)	Ling Yun Bao Dian (V004-V005)
Discourse Style	Declarative, aphoristic, global	Narrative, analytical, therapeutic
Theoretical	Confidence culture,	Jungian psychology, neuroscience

Dimension	Zhang Ti Jelina (V001-V003)	Ling Yun Bao Dian (V004-V005)
Reference	self-help	(DMN), TCM (inflammation)
Vulnerability Presentation	Acknowledged but aestheticized (beach, travel)	Performed within controlled narrative (tears described but not shown raw)
Product Integration	No product promotion	Explicit product promotion (sanitary pads, skincare)
Target Audience	Aspirational women (travel, entrepreneurial success)	Self-diagnosing, "highly sensitive" young women
Core Tension	Resilience vs. vulnerability	Medical vs. psychological explanations of distress

Appendix C: Xu Nao Nao — Three Videos Coding Analysis

Blogger Homepage Link:

https://www.xiaohongshu.com/user/profile/[profile_id]

(for academic use only; link may become inactive over time)

Table C.1: Video Basic Information

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V007	Is It Really Hard to Be Yourself?	2 min	4,200	Self-acceptance: rejecting comparison, ignoring others' opinions, staying away from toxic people

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V008	Youthful Spirit Is a Non-Renewable Resource: Ten Years of Recovery	1 min 50 sec	7,000+	Trauma recovery: from "rat person" to "high energy person" through self-reparenting and physical healing
V009	Bloggers First Made Me Insecure, Then Told Me to Be Confident	2 min 30 sec	7,700	Critique of confidence content: social media as a source of insecurity, not confidence

Table C.2: Full Transcripts

Video	Transcript
V007	"Chit chat time. I don't think I have my voice back completely, it sounds kind of coarse sometimes, but whatever. Today I want to share with you guys some of my thoughts on how to make life easier for yourself, because life is complicated for everyone. I am a firm believer of four letters: IDGAF. It means I don't give a fck. First of all, I think I'm super oblivious of what other people are up to. It's like you do your thing, I do my thing. None of your business, none of my business, period. Other people's opinions don't matter. They don't matter. And something that's also really important: don't compare. I never compare myself with other people. I think some people are just lucky — they are born rich, some people are just born smart, some people are really hard working. Meanwhile, I have things that I'm really good at, I have things that I suck at, and I'm just me. And you know how some people are like, 'Oh in China people compare so much, life is so much easier if you're abroad or whatever.' Honestly, I think it's less about the physical locations, more about your mentality. Some people are gonna keep comparing, like wherever they're at, and they're always gonna be living in jealousy and unhappiness. Also I think

Video	Transcript
	interpersonal relationships really contribute to a lot of the unhappiness in people's lives. Even though I seem like I have a lot of friends, I taught myself to stay away from toxic people, because life is too short to be dealing with their toxicity. Choose wisely who you hang out with. This really helps you stay away from drama. I mean I love watching Bling Empire, it's so fun to see other people's dramas, but I want none of that in my own life. And somehow I feel like I've never really had a hard time trying to be myself. I know exactly what kind of a person I am: I am very loud, I love telling bad jokes, I'm not very ladylike, I care very little, I do whatever I want. If you like me, you like me; if you don't, you don't."
V008	"Recently many people have asked me how I went from being a 'rat person' to a so-called 'high energy person.' Actually, when I was a child, I was a very lively, optimistic, high-energy kid. But at age 20, my heart was damaged and my spirit was completely gone. At an age when others were full of vitality, I had already withered early. Although many people envy my life experiences, those years of displacement brought me more trauma and pain. I felt like my life was constantly breaking and rebuilding. Leaving home early and living under someone else's roof kept me in a very unsettling environment. So I was always dominated by fear. Even after escaping for many years, I still have emotional flashbacks. And I've noticed that many people with immune system problems have experienced long-term suppression and anxiety — their bodies have been in a constant state of stress, so they 'go crazy' and start attacking themselves: attacking their skin, their hair, their internal organs. My entire twenties were spent in a state of trying to save myself. There's this book about CPTSD healing called 'It Didn't Start with You' — it says the trauma you experienced is not your fault, but healing is your own responsibility. I finally understood that my life's theme might be healing and rebuilding. No one can help me, and I cannot change the past. If I am a piece of broken ceramic, then I want to be a master restorer, piecing myself back together, filling in my own vitality, raising myself again. The first piece: leave the traumatic environment. This is the most important and the hardest. For many people, this environment might be a

Video	Transcript
	terrible family they cannot escape, or an exploitative job they need for money, or an unhealthy relationship they are trapped in. But if you don't cut off the source of trauma, no matter how much you heal yourself, you will always be hurt by the outside world. I am very grateful that I grew up. Growing up means I have the right to choose the life I want. I am financially independent. I can stay away from anyone I want. I refuse to let myself be mentally abused again. I also refuse to abuse my body with emotions anymore. That's the second piece: nourish your body from the inside out. Don't let yourself wither anymore. See a doctor — whether it's psychiatry, cardiology, gastroenterology, check your energy, whatever. First fill the physical gaps. Only when you are well can you shine again."
V009	"Chat time. I don't know where I'm going with this video. I didn't write a script, but whatever. I go on Red a lot because I kinda have to, and then every blogger seems to be teaching y'all how to be confident, how to not be insecure. So I'm like, 'Hmm, should I follow the trend? Should I do it?' But then I go through a series of self-introspection and realize that I'm not even that confident myself. How am I gonna teach other people how to be confident? And why am I not confident? Maybe because I spent too much damn time on social media. Don't tell me how to be confident. I was pretty confident until I saw you guys. In the beginning, it was just about your appearance. You see all these pretty people, and you're like, 'Shit, why am I so ugly?' And you start feeling insecure about your looks. I got over it because no one is satisfied with their looks. And if you don't have the guts to get plastic surgery, then there's really nothing you can do about it. You see all these beauty tutorials on Red: how to grow 10 centimeters in 1 month, how to grow from A cup to C cup in 10 days. You people actually believe that? The point is, there's not a lot you can do. What really gets me is what other people are doing that I might have done, could have done — that makes me question my ability. I think I wake up pretty early — until I go on Red and see the latest trend is to wake up at 5:00 am to perform your self-discipline routine, making smoothies, doing yoga, reading books, working, studying, whatever. Then there's also stuff about how much money people

Video	Transcript
	earn. My algorithm just has a million ways to make me feel like a lazy, useless little piece of shit. These are things about your ability, about whether you're working hard enough — and you can actually make a difference. That's why I get really anxious, because I don't want to wake up at 5:00 am. Some people get motivated by stuff like that, but if you find yourself getting anxious, just don't compare and find your own pace. You'll be fine. Worst case, just think about how you're anxious — I'm anxious, everyone's anxious. I'm still living my life. So, peace out."

Table C.3: Visual Strategy (Xu Nao Nao's Distinctive Style)

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
Filter	**No filter** — natural, unprocessed image	**No filter** — natural, unprocessed image	**No filter** — natural, unprocessed image
Color	Natural, comfortable, "fresh and natural" aesthetic — no artificial color grading, colors appear as they are in real life	Natural colors; archival photos/video clips inserted as B-roll retain original color quality	Natural, comfortable, authentic coloring
Composition	Medium close-up, casual framing, not overly polished	Medium close-up; archival footage throughout the narrative to illustrate past experiences	Medium close-up, casual framing

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
Blogger Appearance	Sometimes without makeup (素颜), natural look	Sometimes without makeup; authentic presentation of self across different life stages	Sometimes without makeup, natural
Blogger Expression	Relaxed, conversational, authentic	Vulnerable → determined; facial expressions match emotional arc of trauma narrative	Self-reflective, slightly anxious, then calming
Blogger Posture	Sitting casually at home	Sitting casually; archival footage shows her at different ages/locations	Sitting casually
Setting	Primarily at home (multiple home backgrounds), casual domestic settings	Primarily at home; archival footage shows various past locations	Primarily at home
B-Roll Integration	Minimal; mostly direct address	Significant — archival photos and video clips from her past throughout, illustrating childhood, displacement, trauma period, and recovery	Minimal; mostly direct address

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
		journey	
Camera Language	Direct eye contact, intimate, conversational	Direct eye contact; archival footage provides visual breaks from direct address	Direct eye contact, intimate
Editing Style	Not highly polished — retains a handmade, authentic feel	Not highly polished — the application of archival material is meaningful but not overly produced; feels like personal storytelling	Not highly polished — retains spontaneous, unscripted feel
Overall Visual Mood	Fresh, natural, authentic, "unfiltered" — visually comfortable, not aggressively aestheticized	Authentic, vulnerable, intimate — the archival footage adds historical depth and emotional weight	Fresh, natural, meta-critical, comfortable

Table C.4: Language Strategy

Code Category	V007 (Is It Really Hard to Be Yourself?)	V008 (Youthful Spirit Is a Non-Renewable Resource)	V009 (Bloggers First Made Me Insecure...)

Code Category	V007 (Is It Really Hard to Be Yourself?)	V008 (Youthful Spirit Is a Non-Renewable Resource)	V009 (Bloggers First Made Me Insecure...)
Key Quotes	"IDGAF" / "None of your business, none of my business, period" / "If you like me you like me, if you don't you don't" / "Don't compare" / "Stay away from toxic people"	"From rat person to high energy person" / "Heart damaged, spirit completely gone" / "Healing is your own responsibility" / "If I am broken ceramic, I will be a master restorer" / "Raise myself again"	"I was pretty confident until I saw you guys" / "Don't tell me how to be confident" / "My algorithm has a million ways to make me feel like a useless piece of shit" / "I don't want to wake up at 5:00 am"
Individual Responsibilization	Self-worth framed as individual choice to ignore others — disregards structural pressures that make others' opinions consequential	Explicitly states: "Healing is your own responsibility" — structural harm acknowledged but solution remains individual (self-reparenting, therapy, doctors)	Critiques confidence content as source of insecurity, but solution remains individual ("don't compare, find your own pace") — algorithm mentioned but not structurally challenged

Code Category	V007 (Is It Really Hard to Be Yourself?)	V008 (Youthful Spirit Is a Non-Renewable Resource)	V009 (Bloggers First Made Me Insecure...)
Psychologizing Discourse	Minimal therapeutic language ("toxic people," "drama") — more focused on behavioral rejection of comparison	Uses CPTSD framework (emotional flashbacks, stress response, immune system attacks); references trauma literature; medicalizes emotional distress	Self-reflective, therapeutic language ("self-introspection," "anxiety"); frames social media comparison as psychological problem
Self-Transformation Imperative	"Don't compare" / "Choose wisely who you hang out with" — behavioral isolation as solution	"Leave the traumatic environment" / "Nourish your body from the inside out" / "See a doctor" / "Raise myself again" — comprehensive self-rescue	"Don't compare and find your own pace" / "You'll be fine" — gentler imperative
Structural Occlusion	Why is comparison so pervasive? Why are social	Why was she displaced? Why no social safety net for trauma survivors? —	Algorithm's structural role acknowledged but not challenged; platform capitalism remains unchallenged

Code Category	V007 (Is It Really Hard to Be Yourself?)	V008 (Youthful Spirit Is a Non-Renewable Resource)	V009 (Bloggers First Made Me Insecure...)
	pressures to conform so strong? — omitted	omitted; solution is individual healing	
Key Linguistic Operation	Rejection of social comparison as individual choice	Trauma acknowledgment + self-responsibility for healing	Meta-critique of confidence content + self-deprecating vulnerability

Table C.5: Editing Strategy

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
Rhythm	Slow, conversational, spoken word style	Medium-paced, narrative arc with emotional beats; archival creates rhythmic variation	Slow, conversational, stream-of-consciousness
Transitions	Minimal; straight cuts	Straight cuts; transitions between current footage and archival material are simple (not flashy)	Minimal; straight cuts

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
B-Roll Usage	Minimal	**Extensive** — archival photos and video clips from her past are inserted throughout the video, illustrating her childhood, displacement, trauma period, and recovery journey. This creates a documentary-like authenticity.	Minimal
Editing Polish	Not highly polished — retains spontaneous, "unscripted" feel	Not highly polished — the editing serves the story, not visual spectacle. Archival material is integrated meaningfully without over-production.	Not highly polished — retains spontaneous, unscripted feel
Absence of Imperfection	Voice described as "coarse" — imperfection acknowledged and retained	Trauma described fluently, but the visual of imperfect past moments (old photos, videos) provides authenticity	Stutters, hesitations, self-interruptions — genuine imperfection retained
Editing Rhetoric	"Authentic chit chat" —	"Documentary-style healing narrative" —	"Stream of consciousness critique" — unpolished

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
	unpolished editing reinforces sincerity	archival footage proves the journey, adds credibility	editing reinforces meta-critical authenticity
Disciplinary Function	Performs effortless self-acceptance through unpolished visual style	Performs trauma recovery as achievable through individual effort; archival footage makes the recovery feel real and earned	Performs insecurity as relatable, then resolves through individual mindset shift; unpolished style lowers defense

Table C.6: Narrative Strategy

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
Narrative Structure	Statement of values → Rejection of comparison → Rejection of others' opinions → Rejection of toxic relationships → Self-description	Childhood high energy → Age 20 collapse → Years of trauma/displacement → Fear as dominant emotion → Physical consequences → CPTSD framework → Two-part solution → Self-reparenting metaphor	Social media as source of insecurity → Appearance insecurity (overcome) → Ability insecurity (ongoing) → Algorithm as anxiety machine → Self-reflection → Solution →

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
			Collective anxiety as comfort
Emotional Framing	Builds credibility through "IDGAF" attitude; models behavior	Builds empathy through trauma sharing; offers hope through recovery narrative; archival footage adds visceral emotional weight	Builds resonance through shared experience; uses self-deprecation to lower defenses; offers gentle solution
Transformation Type	No transformation needed — affirmation, not change narrative	Linear transformation: broken → healing → rebuilt (broken ceramic → master restorer)	No transformation; recognition of problem and small mindset shift
Presence of "Struggle"	Minimal (coarse voice, but otherwise confident)	Central — collapse, trauma, fear, immune attacks, emotional flashbacks; **visualized through archival footage**	Central — insecurity, anxiety, comparison, algorithm-induced inadequacy
Hidden Conditions	What enables "not caring"? (economic security, social position) —	What enabled her to leave? (financial independence mentioned, but how achieved?); access to	Algorithm mentioned but not escaped; she is still on Red ("because I kinda

Code Category	V007	V008	V009
	omitted	healthcare — omitted	have to" — why?)
Disciplinary Mechanism	Behavioral demand: stop caring what others think; stop comparing	Behavioral demands: leave toxic environment, see doctors, nourish body, self-reparent	Cognitive demand: reframe comparison as choice, find your own pace

Appendix D: Shi San — Three Videos Coding Analysis

Blogger Homepage Link:

https://www.xiaohongshu.com/user/profile/[profile_id]

(for academic use only; link may become inactive over time)

Table D.1: Video Basic Information

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V010	It Turns Out That Zero Anxiety for Girls Is This Simple	4 min	5,700	Self-care as anxiety management: small daily actions (washing hair, skincare, sleep, hydration, movies, walking) restore sense of control
V011	Age 30 Female Boss: I Deserve Better	3 min	4,400	Reframing 30 as "Odyssey period" not expiration; accepting sensitive temperament; sponsored skincare integration

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V012	Girl, The Most Profitable Track Is Always Yourself	2 min	10,000	Entrepreneurial confidence: career women need brain power, heart power, but physical strength is foundation; health preservation as professional necessity

Table D.2: Full Transcripts

Video	Transcript
V010	"So strange. I feel like crying, very irritable, don't want to reply to messages, don't even want to move. I don't know what's wrong with me. I just came back from seeing a therapist. I thought I had some disease, but the therapist asked me: 'Did you eat?' I realized humans are really simple creatures. Recently, for weight management, I've been dieting, not eating carbs. It's like a car without fuel — my brain can't function, starts overthinking. If the room is messy, my thoughts feel messy too. Staying up late scrolling my phone, not enough sleep — so the next day I wake up very irritable, annoyed at everyone. Even if I haven't washed my hair, it's oily and dirty — I feel like my whole life is ruined. So actually, the sky hasn't fallen. What has fallen is just my state. I discovered that washing your hair is the smallest unit of starting over. If your state has been bad recently, if you feel like life has no hope, if you feel completely lost, do these small things and you will regain control of your life. How many days has it been since you washed your hair? Get up and wash your hair. The moment hot water hits your scalp, your whole body will be activated. Shampoo bubbles will also carry away all the murkiness trapped in your brain. Just 15 minutes. Look in the mirror at your fluffy, clean self — it's like taking off a heavy shell. Your whole body becomes much lighter. The more anxious you are, the worse your state, the more you need to dress up. Now, after staying up late, my face becomes yellow and saggy. These nasolabial folds on my face really look

Video	Transcript
	like tree rings on a tree trunk. Seeing that look, it really reminds me: 'Oh my god, 30 really is different.' So I am very willing to pay for lifting, firming skincare products. Going from loose, dull to firm, bouncy — I feel that is the best psychological treatment for getting rid of age anxiety. If your face doesn't show your age, then 30 is just a number to me. It makes me feel like I still have a long life ahead, my youth isn't over yet. It's not just a change in skin condition — it's an emotional turning point. I also love putting on makeup. Watching myself go from bare-faced, relatively haggard, to gradually becoming more energetic — that kind of 'I'm ready' confidence straightens my back, and my eyes light up. Choosing clothes is even more interesting. Standing in front of my wardrobe matching outfits, I feel like I am deciding what kind of life I want to live today, what role I want to play. Those dressing-up processes are the process of seriously being with myself. And when I'm dressed beautifully, I find that I have special vitality. Now, I treat sleeping as my most important task. When anxiety makes it hard to fall asleep, I take a hot bath 1-2 hours before bed, put down my phone, and fully enjoy the feeling of my body gradually warming up. Don't waste this time — remember to put on a face mask; absorption will be especially good. After bathing, when your body temperature drops, it sends a 'time to sleep' signal to your brain, making it easier to fall asleep. Then I discover that the things that made me collapse at night — after sleeping, after being well-rested — what are they? Suddenly they don't seem so life-threatening anymore. Third thing: try to put down your phone, even just for an hour. Seriously do something time-consuming, effortful, but mindless. I really like spending an hour in the bathroom doing skincare, using heated devices for pore management. Why do these things? Because these things aren't evaluated by performance, don't pursue results. You just need to enjoy the process. And this process will pull you out of that kind of overthinking anxiety. Fourth thing: definitely drink enough water. Because water is the source of all things. We women are made of water — of course we also need to communicate. When you don't drink enough water, your metabolism slows down. Your body needs water to deliver nutrients and ingredients. 'Drink more water' sounds simple, but it's actually hard to

Video	Transcript
	do. One thing that makes me habitually drink water, even actively want to drink water, is using a straw. Then you'll discover that after drinking enough water, bad skin, body discomfort — it's just dehydration. It's not that complicated at all. Fifth thing: definitely watch more movies and documentaries. This is the most cost-effective form of travel and the simplest way to experience different lives. Spend one day each week, turn off bullet screen comments, turn off speed-up, quietly spend time in the movie world. If you want to improve your financial intelligence, I recommend these. If you want female growth, then these. If you want to improve your aesthetic, then these. Sixth thing: People really need to exercise and sweat. But if the gym is hard to stick with, that's okay. Set an easier goal for yourself: walk, move around. Or you can do like me — go shopping, you're also walking, but this way is more interesting. See what new products have come out, how the stores are arranged, what kind of roads you'll see. Even if you don't buy anything, go into a store and smell the new fragrance. These visual and olfactory relaxations are also very healing. Girls who understand me should all relate — after going to the mall, your whole energy returns. Many people have a misconception: wait until my mood is better, wait until I lose weight, wait until I have time to do these things. But the truth is: as soon as you move, your gears will start turning. Restoring energy is really very simple. And humans are really very simple."
V011	"They say 30 is the end of a woman's golden period. So I've already expired. But I feel that this is just the transition from adolescence to the Odyssey period. I even feel like I'm still a minor. Although my high school classmates are all posting wedding photos, and the fashion business I once gave up on, someone in the same industry has become a top player. Looking at me now: I retired for a month, went to Chiang Mai to live, went to Sanya to space out by the sea. I'm not even sure if my entrepreneurial decision during this economic downturn is correct. But so what? I seem adrift, but I know I will eventually arrive. Ithaca is in my hands. So where I want to go is up to me. When your heart is truly settled, when you have your own rhythm, those traits I once desperately wanted to get rid of have instead become

Video	Transcript
	parts of myself that I can now calmly coexist with. For example, the high sensitivity that I used to hate — but now I realize it allows me to better sense my team's emotions, and it has become my creative intuition. Another example: I used to hate my stubbornness, but now it is precisely this stubbornness that has allowed me to hold things together during several dark moments. And also my skin type — I have oily skin. I used to cover it with foundation, press it with strong products, very desperate to cure it. But now my thinking has changed. Instead of fighting against it, I decided to understand it. When I learned that dullness, oil sensitivity, oil acne, oil sagging — the essence is special aging of oily skin — I calmed down. I no longer randomly try all kinds of products that claim to be 'oily skin friendly.' I found an answer that truly understands oily skin anti-aging. For example, La Mer's new oil skin essence lotion and emulsion — specially designed for Asian oily skin. I'd say it's a complete transformation. It has a very clear, mist-like texture. When you pour it in your hand, it's clear and translucent. It absorbs in one second on your face, balancing your skin's water-oil ratio very stably. Then it suppresses all the dullness and sallowness. The tiredness and oiliness on your whole face visibly change. It also tightens pores. My skin becomes very refined, soft and sticky-rice-like to the touch. Very worry-free — after applying it, your skin stays refined and bright all day. Then you add another layer of the oil skin emulsion — a texture I have never experienced before. The first time you apply it, it's watery and very light. After spreading it, that non-greasy, non-heavy soft moist feeling appears. After it absorbs, your skin feels like advanced soft focus — like lightly dusting a very fine powder. It precisely manages oil, adjusting your skin's water-oil ratio perfectly. It's like raising your skin to be healthy. On one hand, it repairs proteins, protecting your layered barriers. On the other hand, it vigorously supplements collagen. When you tighten your skin and hold it up steadily, your lines can only go upward. So this jawline can become very clear and sharp. After using it, my whole face is tight and full. Since starting my business, I have to make dozens of decisions every day. I really don't have energy to spend on skincare. So these two steps are simple and neat, bringing me a very tangible sense of security. That clean, bright,

Video	Transcript
	bare-faced state in the morning — it really makes my mood good all day. So you see, 30 doesn't have to be the age of docking — it can be the port of departure for a second journey. If you are also in the middle of a long drift, don't be afraid. It took Odysseus 10 years to get home. We are still on the road. There may be sea monsters, but there is also moonlight. There may be getting lost, but there is also the gentle support of self-care. Even if it's just a nightly skincare ritual healing."
V012	"Become a woman who knows how to make money. You too can. The first challenge of starting work is adjusting your schedule and your state. No time to ease into it — just force yourself to start. 7:30 AM discussing art. After starting my business, I increasingly understand that whether male or female, success depends on brain power, consumes heart power, but ultimately what sustains you is physical strength. Happy New Year. It's really congested today. Working overtime today — emotional stress relief. My lower back. I already have an appointment for tomorrow morning. After 30, you automatically fall in love with health preservation. Today I'm cooking apple and astragalus water to bring to the office — to replenish and tonify energy. My friend didn't get a ticket, didn't come back, so I'll just order takeout. Travel is like coronation along the way, but unfortunately I've missed all the scenery. Almost there — let's go to the office. The most important thing for starting work is to handle the SOT properly. So we need to judge this matter ourselves based on our own interests. This is a very negative factor for our long-term development. Because I'm weighing — if we start this precedent, it feels like later... then you present your selling points — that works. Our office health preservation doesn't need ritual. Whatever can be done during work gaps is best. Please sit. 2 million in cash. Leaving — get off work. The last step of the day: foot bath. While soaking my feet, I review today's work and review tomorrow's schedule. Good night."

Table D.3: Visual Strategy (Shi San's Distinctive Style)

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
Filter	Polished, aestheticized — likely mild filter for skin smoothing and brightening	Polished, aestheticized — consistent with premium brand integration	Natural but polished — professional yet approachable
Color	Warm, soft, inviting — "luxurious comfort" aesthetic	Warm, radiant, premium — designed to showcase skin clarity and product efficacy	Natural warm tones — balanced between professional and cozy
Composition	Medium to close-up shots; blogger centered; alternating between direct address and soft-focus beauty shots	Medium close-up; emphasis on facial skin texture; product placement shots interwoven	Medium shots; office setting; laptop, documents, phone present to signal professionalism and busy schedule
Blogger Appearance	Impeccable — refined makeup, polished hair, stylish attire; her appearance is itself an aspirational	Impeccable — glowing skin, minimal-but-polished makeup, elegant styling consistent with premium skincare positioning	Professional yet relaxed — styled for office but approachable

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
	product		
Blogger Expression	Warm, relatable, slightly vulnerable opening → confident, empowered closing	Calm, self-assured, reflective — demonstrating the "settled" inner state she describes	Focused, efficient, slightly hurried but handling it — "boss energy"
Blogger Posture	Sitting in comfortable home setting; occasionally standing by mirror or wardrobe	Sitting, speaking to camera; product demonstration moments	Moving through day: office chair, standing at desk, walking out at end of day
Setting	Luxurious home interiors — elegant bathroom, organized wardrobe, comfortable living room; every frame conveys "successful person's	Elegant interior; clean, organized background — nothing that detracts from the premium aesthetic	High-end office; clean desk, professional environment; home setting for morning/evening routines

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
	sanctuary"		
Camera Language	Direct eye contact, intimate, conversational — aspirational intimacy	Direct eye contact; product shots integrated as natural extensions of her routine	Direct eye contact for advice segments; wider shots for office/action sequences
Overall Visual Mood	"Aspirational comfort" — she shares struggles but lives beautifully; anxiety is temporary, her lifestyle is the solution	"Premium self-care" — every frame reinforces that investing in quality products is investing in yourself	"Boss aesthetic" — busy but in control; health preservation is integrated into professional success
Visual Rhetoric	Empathy + Aspiration — she describes the same problems you have, but her solution produces a beautiful, polished result. The implication: follow her steps, become her.	Transformation + Luxury — the problem is tangible; the solution is tangible; the result is aspirational.	Authenticity + Authority — you see her work, you see her health preservation, you see her leave at the end of the day. She practices what she preaches. Her success is evidence her method works.

Table D.4: Language Strategy

Code Category	V010 (Zero Anxiety)	V011 (Age 30 Female Boss)	V012 (Most Profitable Track is Yourself)
Key Quotes	"Washing your hair is the smallest unit of starting over"; "The more anxious you are, the more you need to dress up"; "As soon as you move, your gears will start turning"	"30 is not the age of docking — it's the port of departure"; "When your heart is truly settled, you have your own rhythm"; "Instead of fighting against it, understand it"	"What sustains you is physical strength"; "Force yourself to start"; "After 30, you automatically fall in love with health preservation"
Individual Responsibilization	Anxiety is framed as a state management problem — the solution is individual actions. Structural causes of anxiety are absent.	Age anxiety is reframed as individual mindset shift. Structural age discriminatio n is not addressed.	Professional success is framed as individual discipline. Structural barriers for women in business are absent.
Psychologizing	Uses clinical language	Uses	Minimal

Code Category	V010 (Zero Anxiety)	V011 (Age 30 Female Boss)	V012 (Most Profitable Track is Yourself)
Discourse	but redirects to physical solutions — "you're just hungry/dehydrated/tired." Your problem isn't pathology, it's not washing your hair.	therapeutic concepts — Jungian-lite self-acceptance discourse.	psychologizing — more behavioral and productivity-focused.
Self-Transformation Imperative	Strong action-orientation: "Get up and wash your hair," "put down your phone," "drink enough water," "go for a walk." The solution is always a small action.	Cognitive reframing: "Don't fight against it, understand it." The transformation is internal acceptance.	Behavioral demands: "Adjust your schedule," "force yourself to start," "handle the SOT," "foot bath and review." Success is a daily discipline.
Structural Occlusion	Why are women anxious? The video answers: because you didn't wash your hair. The implication: your problems are this small and solvable.	Why do women feel their value declines at 30? The video answers: it's your mindset. Age	Why is it hard for women to succeed in business? The video answers: you need to manage your energy better. Structural barriers are not mentioned.

Code Category	V010 (Zero Anxiety)	V011 (Age 30 Female Boss)	V012 (Most Profitable Track is Yourself)
		discrimination, workplace bias, beauty standards — not mentioned.	
Key Linguistic Operation	Action as antidote to rumination — stop thinking, start doing.	Reframing as resistance — change the meaning of 30, of sensitivity, of stubbornness.	Business as embodied practice — success flows from physical maintenance. Health preservation is not separate from work — it is work's foundation.

Table D.5: Editing Strategy

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
Rhythm	Gentle, conversational pace — no rush, matching the "relaxed but effective" message	Sophisticated, measured — allows product shots to land, aligns with premium positioning	Brisk but not rushed — efficient, like the blogger herself

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
Transitions	Smooth, natural — soft cuts between direct address and action sequences	Elegant — product integration is seamless, not jarring	Efficient — quick cuts between different scenes, maintaining momentum
B-Roll Usage	Extensive — shampooing, skincare application, wardrobe selection, bathing, walking; all illustrate her verbal advice visually	Moderate — primarily direct address with interwoven product demonstration	Moderate — office scenes, phone use, walking, foot bath; visual evidence of her daily routine
Sound Design	Gentle background music — not intrusive, soothing, matches "unwinding" theme	Premium, spa-like music — consistent with brand positioning	Upbeat but not aggressive — "getting things done" energy
Editing Polish	Polished but warm — professional but not cold. Every frame is intentional, aesthetically pleasing.	Highly polished — product shots are commercial-quality; the blogger's skin is the proof.	Polished but real — "authentic" within a premium frame; she is busy but her environment is organized, her appearance is maintained.

Table D.6: Narrative Strategy

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
Narrative Structure	Problem → Diagnosis → Solution (6 actions) → Reassurance	Problem → Reframe → Acceptance → Action → Affirmation	Opening → Morning routine → Work → Office health preservation → End of day → Good night
Emotional Framing	Validate → Reassure → Instruct → Inspire	Acknowledge cultural script → Subvert → Explain → Model → Extend	Show → Extract → Affirm
Transformation Type	State transformation — from collapsed to in-control. Transformation is behavioral.	Cognitive transformation — from seeing 30 as end to seeing it as beginning.	Embodied transformation — success lives in your daily routine, your tea, your foot bath.
Role Positioning	The blogger is you + 1 — she has the same struggles, but she has figured it out.	The blogger is successful proof — she has a business, she manages a team, she has found answers.	The blogger is boss and coach — she runs a company, makes decisions, manages millions.
Product Integration	No sponsored product — but self-care actions	Sponsored — integrated as the "answer" she found	No sponsored product — but the lifestyle is

Code Category	V010	V011	V012
	create a consumer pathway.	after years of trial and error.	implicitly aspirational.
Disciplinary Mechanism	Behavioral — you must act. Thinking about anxiety is part of the problem; doing small things is the solution.	Cognitive + Consumer — you must think differently, and the tangible expression of that new thinking is purchasing the right product.	Lifestyle — you must integrate health preservation into your workday. Success is not separate from self-care.

Table D.7: Product Promotion Analysis

Video	Product	Integration Strategy	How Product Relates to Confidence Discourse
V010	None (indirect)	Describes skincare, bathing, masking as self-care practices — creates need for products that enable these practices	Confidence comes from small actions of self-care. The implication: invest in products that make these actions pleasurable and effective.
V011	La Mer Oil Skin Essence Lotion + Emulsion	Positioned as the answer she found after years of trial and error. Framed as specific to her needs. The product demonstration	Self-acceptance is not passive — it means investing in what works for your specific needs. Confidence is the result of correct product use. 30 is not expiration if your skin doesn't

Video	Product	Integration Strategy	How Product Relates to Confidence Discourse
		emphasizes texture and results.	show it — and this product makes that possible.
V012	None (indirect)	Mentions making tea, foot bath at end of day. No sponsored product.	Confidence is embodied. Taking care of your body is not separate from professional success — it is its foundation.

Appendix E: Yang Tian Zhen — Three Videos Coding Analysis

Blogger Homepage Link:

https://www.xiaohongshu.com/user/profile/[profile_id]

(for academic use only; link may become inactive over time

Table E.1: Video Basic Information

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V013	Most Girls Are Not Not Good Enough, They Are Just Too Used to Self-Denial	2 min 25 sec	7,000+	Self-acceptance: refusing self-denial, being your own strongest ally
V014	Self-Love for Women Is Both a Choice and a Method	1 min 40 sec	6,200	Boundary-setting: prioritizing own feelings, finding win-win solutions without self-sacrifice

Video	Title	Duration	Likes	Core Theme
V015	The Answer to Many Things Is Already There	2 min 45 sec	5,000	Energy management: intention as the source of energy, transforming energy through purpose

Table E.2: Full Transcripts

Video	Transcript
V013	"I think the best thing I've done is that I have never denied myself. Not at any moment — even when there were online storms, when the whole world was denying me — I never denied myself because of that. I think I am great. Even when the whole world wants to erase me, I know that these people's judgments of me are because they don't understand me, because they assume who I am from some phenomena. But it will never make me doubt myself for a single moment. I know very clearly that I am an upright, kind person who wants to use my own efforts to make my life better and make this world a little better. My mother used to say I'm fat, saying 'You're so fat, you'll never find a boyfriend.' I always thought that was illogical — fat is just one of my characteristics, it's not a flaw. But many people will label you, judge your gains and losses based on their assumptions about you, and use that to attack you. So you must love yourself. At any moment when you want to deny yourself, you must tell yourself: I am my own most steadfast teammate. I am my own greatest foundation. Even if the whole world denies me, I want to stand by my own side and support myself. Believe in yourself, be your own teammate, don't be your own enemy. I know many friends easily deny themselves. It's not your fault — it's because in the environment we grew up in, we easily developed this habit. There is always a standard called 'success,' a standard called 'happiness,' as if anything outside those standards is wrong. I already live my life quite freely, and people still tell me: 'Look at you, no matter how successful you are, aren't you still going to grow old alone?' Yes, because I am human, I chose to live alone. That has

Video	Transcript
	nothing to do with whether you are successful or not. I understand why people are sometimes troubled by public opinion — because everyone thinks that way. When you don't think that way, it's very hard to firmly believe that you are right. Some people say, 'That's because you're successful, that's why you can make this choice.' I don't think so. It's because I made these choices that I became successful. Because I have always firmly believed that I am a capable person, a person who has always been working hard for my life. I know very clearly who I am. So I will not waver because of anyone's evaluation — even if that person is someone I respect, someone I care about, or even someone I love. It is normal for them to have misunderstandings about me because they are not me. But I know who I am. So every one of us really needs to know who we are. That is very important."
V014	"Your own feelings or others' feelings — between these two, how do you prioritize? Recently, a relative wanted me to accompany them to a social dinner. His friend wanted to meet me. This relative is very close to me. If I accepted the invitation, I felt like it would be at least two and a half hours of full-body tension, saying things I didn't mean, doing things I really didn't want to do. But if I refused, there would be some guilt — the feeling that you shouldn't refuse a relative's request for help. Later, I abstracted the problem and took myself out of it. The question is: should a person prioritize protecting their own feelings or prioritizing others' feelings? Removing the individual, looking purely at the matter, I think a person should of course prioritize protecting their own feelings. You yourself are the most worthy of care in this world, the person you should love. So I made a decision: I would not go to the dinner. If I had no feelings about it, I would have gone — it wouldn't have mattered. But since it already caused me painful feelings, I shouldn't do it. Then I thought: what he might need is for me to establish some connection with his friends, or to satisfy some of his social needs. The dinner was just the means he proposed. So I thought: is there a means that satisfies him without making me uncomfortable? In the end, I honestly told him about the discomfort I would feel and the more

Video	Transcript
	reasonable solution I was hoping for. He agreed very much. Later, we 共同 came up with a solution that solved the problem. Because I thought: if he wants to force me to do something he knows I don't like to satisfy his needs, then I can consider his feelings even less. This is just a small example. Many times, because of other things, we have strong internal conflicts. At such times, I suggest definitely seeking help — whether from friends or family you think are more experienced, or from professionals. Seeking help is better than suffering alone. I think finding a consensus method not only helps you 突破 moral dilemmas but also better protects yourself. Of course, everyone's priorities are different. Some people put caring for others' feelings at a higher priority level. So I think respecting your own internal priorities and finding a win-win solution is the truly reasonable resolution."
V015	"People's energy comes from many different sources. Some people's energy comes from static things — from introspective seeking, learning, reading. Some people's energy comes from external things — from sports, competition, expression. Some people's energy comes from feedback — from being liked, being noticed, being praised. I've been thinking: what is growth? I now increasingly realize that for me, my energy is changing. In the past, a lot of my energy came from the outside — from proving to the world how strong you are, how capable you are. But at this moment, when I see this question, new thoughts emerge. The initial intention behind anything is the source of your energy. The motivation when you decide to do something is very important. For example, recently I've been taking English classes. I deeply feel that I face significant difficulties in learning English. So I asked myself: how can I effectively help myself learn English well? Because I am someone who needs supervision. So I thought: I'll find a teacher to live stream English. With so many people watching me learn, I can't not study hard, right? This is actually an external condition I set for myself. Since I want to find an English teacher to teach me, can I find this teacher through live streaming? The process of finding an English teacher turned out to be more noticed than I expected. So I

Video	Transcript
	started an account for learning English, with live classes twice a week. Why did I mention 'initial intention'? Because my intention was for myself — to learn English well — that's what motivated this entire series of actions. Then as I did it, I found it seemed to attract a lot of attention. I got a lot of feedback from friends in my real life. They were actually learning English with me. Many celebrity friends also told me: 'Can you introduce a teacher to me? I also want to learn English well.' So I realized: even though I was doing it for myself, when you persist in doing something, it gives different people different feedback and stimulation. Every time I live stream, countless people enter my stream. Some people are listening to the lesson, some people are commenting on my pronunciation. I've already made up my mind: I don't need to care about these things, which is why I decided to live stream class. But it's hard to completely ignore them. I can only not let them affect my teaching. But after every class, I can't help wanting to respond to some comments, because I see many different initial intentions in them. Your different original intention brings different energy to people. What I see now is more energy. So now when I judge my own behaviors, I stop and ask myself: is what I'm doing now because I want to show myself off, because I want to seem impressive? Or do I truly want to do this? Is it because I like it, or because I truly want to help others? Initial intention is very important. I think in terms of accumulating energy, a person's original intention — where it starts — if it carries a kind and positive possibility, then the result may be good. This is a bit convoluted, but what I really want to say is this kind of energy: we can adjust our starting intention and observe our own behavior, thereby transforming this energy. This is the main point I want to make."

Table E.3: Visual Strategy

Code Category	V013	V014	V015

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
Filter	No obvious filter — image clear, natural skin texture visible	No obvious filter — professional, clear image	No obvious filter — natural, clear
Color	Business/office tones — neutral, professional, not overly warm or cold	Neutral, professional, consistent with office setting	Neutral, natural, consistent across all three videos
Composition	Medium close-up, blogger centered, direct eye contact	Medium close-up, blogger centered, direct eye contact, occasional looking to side	Medium close-up, blogger centered, direct eye contact, engaged
Blogger Appearance	Professional, polished but not over-styled; business casual attire	Professional, consistent with executive/entrepreneur brand	Professional, consistent across all videos
Blogger Expression	Warm but authoritative — explains with conviction, occasional gentle smile	Calm, reasoned, occasionally smiling when making her point	Engaged, thoughtful, animated when describing her English learning journey

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
Setting	Office setting with business-style decor — professional, consistent with her "boss" brand	Same professional office setting	Same professional office setting, slightly more relaxed for English learning discussion
Camera Language	Direct eye contact, authoritative but approachable — "coach" positioning	Direct eye contact, intimate but professional	Direct eye contact, engaging, slightly more animated for storytelling sections
Overall Visual Mood	Professional authority	Rational boundary-setting	Reflective practitioner

Table E.4: Language Strategy

Code Category	V013 (Self-Denial)	V014 (Self-Love as Choice)	V015 (Energy & Intention)
Key Quotes	"I have never denied myself"; "I am my own most steadfast teammate"; "I am	"You should of course prioritize protecting your own feelings"; "Seeking help is	"The initial intention is the source of your energy"; "When you persist in

Code Category	V013 (Self-Denial)	V014 (Self-Love as Choice)	V015 (Energy & Intention)
	my own greatest foundation"; "Fat is just one of my characteristics, it's not a flaw"	better than suffering alone"; "Find a win-win solution"	doing something, it gives different people different feedback and stimulation"; "We can transform this energy"
Individual Responsibilization	Self-denial is a habit from childhood environment, but solution is individual. Structural factors acknowledged but not solved.	Boundary-setting as individual skill. Structural pressures noted but not confronted.	Energy management as individual practice. Structural factors not addressed.
Psychologizing Discourse	Therapeutic language ("self-denial," "self-doubt") but pragmatic rather than clinical. Solution is self-definition and refusing internalized criticism.	Conflict-resolution framework — rational, business-like approach to emotional boundary-setting.	Self-help/spiritual language ("initial intention," "energy source," "transforming energy") blending mindfulness with productivity.

Code Category	V013 (Self-Denial)	V014 (Self-Love as Choice)	V015 (Energy & Intention)
Self-Transformation Imperative	"You must love yourself"; "Be your own teammate"; "Know who you are" — explicit commands.	"Seek help"; "Find a win-win solution"; "Respect your own internal priorities" — actionable, rational steps.	"Adjust your initial intention"; "Observe your own behavior"; "Transform this energy" — reflective, iterative.
Structural Occlusion	Acknowledges childhood environment that teaches self-denial and narrow success/happiness standards. Why these standards exist, why women are targeted — not examined.	Acknowledges familial pressure and internalized guilt. Solutions are individual negotiation strategies, not changes to expectation structures.	Does not address structural factors affecting women's energy or capacity. Focus is entirely internal.
Key Linguistic Operation	Reframing denial as habit, not truth	Rationalizing boundary-setting	Internalizing energy management

Table E.5: Editing Strategy

Code Category	V013	V014	V015

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
Rhythm	Conversational, relaxed pace	Moderate pace, thoughtful pauses	Slightly faster storytelling, reflective pauses for philosophy
Transitions	Minimal; straight cuts	Minimal; straight cuts	Minimal; straight cuts
B-Roll Usage	Minimal — primarily direct address	Minimal — primarily direct address	Minimal — primarily direct address
Editing Polish	Professional but not over-produced	Professional, clean	Professional, clean
Sound Design	Clear voice audio; no background music	Clear voice audio; minimal to no music	Clear voice audio; minimal music if any
Overall Editing Rhetoric	Content-first professionalism	Rational problem-solving aesthetic	Reflective practitioner aesthetic

Table E.6: Narrative Strategy

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
Narrative Structure	Critique →	Problem →	Observation →

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
	Response → Reframe → Solution → Generalization	Abstraction → Decision → Solution → Generalization	Self-interrogation → Example → Insight → Generalization
Emotional Framing	Validate shared experience → Model correct response → Empower viewer	Establish relatable dilemma → Model rational decision-making → Normalize seeking help → Affirm viewer's right to choose	Establish shared problem → Model self-interrogation → Share personal example → Extract universal insight
Transformation Type	Cognitive reframing — from internalizing others' judgments to clear self-knowledge	Decision-making framework — from guilt-driven people-pleasing to rational self-protection	Energy mindset transformation — from external validation seeking to internal intention cultivation
Use of Personal Example	Mother's criticism, online storms, "die alone" comments	Dinner invitation dilemma with close relative	English learning live stream example
Disciplinary	Cognitive	Behavioral	Reflective

Code Category	V013	V014	V015
Mechanism	discipline — reject internalized criticism, be your own teammate	discipline — set boundaries, seek help, find win-win solutions	discipline — examine motivations, identify intention, transform energy
Positioning of Self	The example — her success proves her approach works	The problem-solver — demonstrating a teachable skill	The practitioner — still learning, still reflecting, still transforming

Table E.7: Key Findings from Yang Tian Zhen

Finding	Description
Refusal of self-denial as core value	Unlike other bloggers who diagnose women's problems and offer solutions, Yang's starting point is more fundamental: you must stop denying yourself. Self-denial is a societal lesson women are taught. The solution is not external validation — it is refusing the premise that you need it.
Rational boundary-setting without guilt	Yang abstracts problems, removes relational context, and asks universal questions. Her answer is clear: prioritize your own feelings. This is not selfish — it is correct logic. Win-win solutions satisfy both parties without self-sacrifice.
Energy as transformable through intention	"Initial intention" (起心动念) is the source of energy. Acting from external motivation depletes energy. Acting from internal,

Finding	Description
	authentic intention generates energy. Energy is not something you have or don't have — it is something you can transform.
The "successful person" platform	Yang's authority derives from demonstrated success. Unlike bloggers who perform vulnerability to build relatability, Yang performs clarity to build authority. Her professional office setting, polished appearance, and direct delivery reinforce this.
Absence of product sponsorship	Unlike Ling Yun Bao Dian and Shi San, Yang does not integrate sponsored products here. Her "product" is her worldview, her framework, her example. This strengthens her authority — she is not selling anything except a way of thinking.

Appendix F: Cross-Blogger Comparative Analysis

Table F.1: Blogger Profile Comparison

Blogger	Style Type	Visual Aesthetic	Key Discourse	Target Audience	Product Integration
Zhang Ti Jelina	Value Declaration	Filtered, bright, travel/beach	Aphoristic confidence declarations	Aspirational women	None
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Therapeutic Self-Diagnosis	Vintage/retro, pink tones, artistic	Jungian psychology + neuroscienc	Self-diagnosing young women	Yes (sanitary pads, skincare)

Blogger	Style Type	Visual Aesthetic	Key Discourse	Target Audience	Product Integration
		B-roll	e		
Xu Nao Nao	Trauma Recovery	No filter, natural, archival footage	CPTSD + trauma therapy + social media critique	Social media users with comparison anxiety	None
Shi San	Aspirational Lifestyle	Polished, luxurious, commercial quality	Actionable self-care + age reframing	30-ish professionals with disposable income	Yes (La Mer)
Yang Tian Zhen	Professional Authority	No obvious filter, office setting, clean	Self-definition + boundary-setting + energy management	Career women, entrepreneurs, high-performers	None

Table F.2: Language Strategy Comparison

Blogger	Individual Responsibilization	Psychologizing Discourse	Self-Transformation Imperative	Structural Occlusion
Zhang Ti Jelina	Strong — giving up = not strong enough	Medium — emotions reduced to daily needs	Strong — recovery is mandatory	High — why women need recovery? omitted
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Medium — self-knowledge delay = individual responsibility	Strong — emotions reframed as "inflammation" or "archetypes"	Medium — body acceptance as learnable skill	Medium — why women experience inflammation? omitted
Xu Nao Nao	Medium — healing is individual responsibility	Strong — CPTSD, emotional flashbacks, immune attacks	Strong — leave, heal, self-reparent	Low-moderate — acknowledges trauma source
Shi San	Strong — anxiety is state management problem	Medium — therapist, diagnosis, but redirected to physical	Strong — action-oriented: wash hair, drink water, walk	High — why women anxious? because they didn't wash hair

Blogger	Individual Responsibilization	Psychologizing Discourse	Self-Transformation Imperative	Structural Occlusion
Yang Tian Zhen	Medium — self-denial is habit, solution is individual	Medium — therapeutic language but pragmatic	Medium — know yourself, be your own teammate	Medium — acknowledges childhood environment

Table F.3: Visual Strategy Comparison

Blogger	Filter	Color	Setting	Blogger Appearance	Overall Mood
Zhang Ti Jelina	Filtered, bright	Blue, white, bright tones	Beach (travel), simple interior	Polished, aspirational	Encouraging, empowering
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Vintage/retro	Pink, warm tones	Home settings, multiple rooms	Polished but "authentic"	Intimate, confessional
Xu Nao Nao	No filter	Natural, comfortable	Home settings, casual	Sometimes without makeup, natural	Fresh, natural, authentic
Shi	Polished,	Warm,	Luxurious	Impeccabl	Aspirationa

Blogger	Filter	Color	Setting	Blogger Appearance	Overall Mood
San	commercial quality	soft, inviting	home, high-end office	e, aspirational	l comfort, premium
Yang Tian Zhen	No obvious filter	Neutral, professional	Office setting, professional	Professional, polished	Professional authority

Table F.4: Editing Strategy Comparison

Blogger	Rhythm	Transitions	B-Roll Usage	Editing Polish	Imperfection
Zhang Ti Jelina	Slow, soothing	No transitions	Minimal	Polished (one-shot)	None
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Medium-paced	Straight cuts	Moderate (artistic)	Polished	None (performed within frame)
Xu Nao Nao	Medium-slow	Straight cuts	Extensive (archival footage)	Not highly polished	Yes (stutters, hesitations)

Blogger	Rhythm	Transitions	B-Roll Usage	Editing Polish	Imperfection
Shi San	Gentle, conversational	Smooth, natural	Extensive (action sequences)	Polished but warm	None (polished vulnerability)
Yang Tian Zhen	Conversational, relaxed	Minimal, straight cuts	Minimal	Professional, clean	None

Table F.5: Narrative Strategy Comparison

Blogger	Narrative Structure	Transformation Type	Role Positioning	Disciplinary Mechanism
Zhang Ti Jelina	Mini three-part (vulnerability → pause → recovery)	Cyclical commitment	You + 1 (ahead on path)	Behavioral — you must recover and become stronger
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Problem diagnosis → reframe → solution	Cognitive reframing	Self-diagnosing peer	Cognitive — accept confusion as growth
Xu Nao Nao	Trauma → recovery → self-reparentin	Linear transformation	Trauma survivor who healed	Behavioral + Cognitive — leave, heal,

Blogger	Narrative Structure	Transformation Type	Role Positioning	Disciplinary Mechanism
	g			self-reparent
Shi San	Problem → diagnosis → 6 actions → reassurance	State transformation	You + 1 (polished version)	Behavioral — stop thinking, start doing
Yang Tian Zhen	Critique → response → reframe → solution	Self-definition	Successful proof, coach	Cognitive — know yourself, be your own teammate

Table F.6: Product Integration Comparison

Blogger	Product Integration	Integration Strategy	How Product Relates to Confidence
Zhang Ti Jelina	None	N/A	N/A
Ling Yun Bao Dian	Yes (sanitary pads, skincare)	Personal story → problem → product as solution	Self-care requires the right products
Xu Nao Nao	None	N/A	N/A
Shi San	Yes (La Mer)	Age reframing → skin problem →	Confidence is purchased through

Blogger	Product Integration	Integration Strategy	How Product Relates to Confidence
		premium product as answer	correct product use
Yang Tian Zhen	None	N/A	N/A

Table F.7: Core Argument Summary

Blogger	Core Argument	Confidence Culture Mechanism
Zhang Ti Jelina	"You are strong. You will come back stronger."	Resilience as mandatory recovery
Ling Yun Bao Dian	"Your sensitivity is not a flaw — it is inflammation/archetype."	Medicalization/Therapeutic reframing as self-acceptance
Xu Nao Nao	"Trauma is not your fault, but healing is your responsibility."	Trauma acknowledgment + individual solution
Shi San	"Your anxiety is just unwashed hair and dehydration. Do small actions."	Behavioral action as state management
Yang Tian Zhen	"Know who you are. Be your own teammate. Do not deny yourself."	Self-definition as resistance to external judgment

Appendix G: Coding Framework Summary Table

Dimension	Code Category	Definition	Theory Source
Language	Individual Responsibilization	Framing structural problems as individual's lack of confidence	Orgad & Gill, 2022
Language	Psychologizing Discourse	Reframing social problems as psychological conditions	Orgad & Gill, 2022
Language	Self-Transformation Imperative	Explicit commands to change oneself	Orgad & Gill, 2022
Language	Structural Occlusion	Systematic omission of structural factors	Orgad & Gill, 2022
Visual	Filter	Use of digital filters to alter image	Toxic positivity
Visual	Color	Dominant color palette	Toxic positivity
Visual	Composition	Framing of blogger in frame	Toxic positivity
Editing	Rhythm	Pace of cuts and transitions	Foucault, 1988
Editing	Transitions	Types of scene changes	Foucault, 1988

Dimension	Code Category	Definition	Theory Source
Editing	Editing Traces	Evidence of cutting/assembly	Foucault, 1988
Narrative	Narrative Structure	Overall story arc	Hochschild, 1983
Narrative	Emotional Framing	How emotions are evoked	Hochschild, 1983
Narrative	Transformation Type	Nature of change presented	Hochschild, 1983

Appendix H: Sample Selection Criteria

Criterion	Description
Platform	Xiaohongshu (RedNote)
Blogger Type	Female head bloggers (followers > 500,000)
Content Type	Vlogs with "confidence," "self-love," or "self-improvement" themes
Time Range	January 2024 — December 2025
Interaction	Video likes > 1,000 per video (for meaningful engagement)
Diversity	Five style types: value declaration, therapeutic self-diagnosis, trauma recovery, aspirational lifestyle, professional authority

Criterion	Description
Sample Size	5 bloggers × 3 videos = 15 videos total